

U.S. Metro Economic Health Report

50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas

Percentile-Based Composite Scoring · 8 Metrics · BLS & FRED Data
85% Employment / 15% Housing · October 2026

TOP PERFORMERS

#1	A	Salt Lake City	71.7
#2	A	Raleigh	70.7
#3	A	St. Louis	69.2
#4	A	Las Vegas	69.2
#5	A-	Charlotte	68.0
#6	A	Austin	68.0
#7	A-	Hartford	67.1

MARKETS UNDER PRESSURE

#50	D	Detroit	19.0
#49	D	Chicago	26.4
#48	D	Louisville	28.7
#47	D	Grand Rapids	29.6
#46	C-	Jacksonville	31.7
#45	C-	Indianapolis	32.1
#44	C-	Fresno	33.8

GRADE DISTRIBUTION

A+ / A / A-	9 cities
B+ / B / B-	15 cities
C+ / C / C-	22 cities
D	4 cities

Full Rankings

All 50 Metropolitan Statistical Areas · Sorted by composite score · October 2026

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
1	Salt Lake City Salt Lake City-Murray	A	71.7	3.7%	+4.5%	+2.5%	+0.3%	58 days
2	Raleigh Raleigh-Cary	A	70.7	3.1%	+3.2%	+2.2%	-1.6%	59 days
3	St. Louis St. Louis	A	69.2	3.9%	+3.5%	+0.7%	-1.3%	50 days
4	Las Vegas Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas	A	69.2	4.8%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-0.2%	58 days
5	Charlotte Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia	A-	68.0	3.7%	+4.2%	+1.5%	-1.5%	64 days
6	Austin Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos	A	68.0	3.9%	+5.1%	+1.2%	+0.6%	80 days
7	Hartford Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford	A-	67.1	2.7%	+5.3%	+1.9%	+2.8%	35 days
8	Cincinnati Cincinnati	A-	67.0	3.6%	+8.1%	+0.3%	-1.4%	44 days
9	Philadelphia Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington	A-	65.9	4.4%	+2.1%	+0.8%	+1.2%	49 days
10	Kansas City Kansas City	B+	61.4	3.9%	+7.3%	+0.7%	-2.1%	50 days
11	Dallas Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington	B+	61.3	4.4%	+4.0%	+1.0%	+0.6%	62 days
12	Baltimore Baltimore-Columbia-Towson	B+	60.5	3.9%	+6.0%	-0.5%	-0.5%	46 days
13	Orlando Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford	B+	60.3	4.6%	+6.1%	+0.8%	+0.4%	77 days
14	Pittsburgh Pittsburgh	B	58.6	3.9%	+3.3%	-0.1%	+1.1%	54 days
15	Seattle Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue	B	57.6	4.8%	+5.4%	+0.9%	-0.5%	51 days
16	Tampa Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater	B-	54.8	4.7%	+5.1%	+0.9%	+0.3%	76 days
17	Los Angeles Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim	B-	54.0	4.8%	+3.4%	+1.8%	-1.9%	55 days
18	Miami Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach	B-	53.9	3.7%	+7.7%	+0.3%	+0.4%	85 days
19	Columbus Columbus	B-	52.8	3.3%	+4.2%	+0.1%	-2.2%	48 days
20	Atlanta Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell	B-	51.8	3.4%	+3.1%	-0.5%	+1.2%	60 days
21	San Antonio San Antonio-New Braunfels	B-	51.2	4.5%	+3.7%	+0.5%	+0.2%	71 days
22	Nashville Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	B-	51.2	3.2%	+3.9%	+0.7%	-1.3%	62 days
23	Cleveland Cleveland	B-	50.7	3.4%	+0.9%	+0.6%	+1.8%	55 days
24	Washington DC Washington-Arlington-Alexandria	B-	50.4	3.8%	+5.8%	-2.0%	-3.6%	43 days

#	METRO	GRADE	SCORE	UNEMP.	WAGE YOY	EMP. YOY	CLF YOY	DOM
25	San Francisco San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont	C+	49.7	4.6%	+5.8%	+0.6%	-2.3%	37 days
26	Houston Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands	C+	48.5	5.0%	+1.2%	+1.3%	+0.6%	55 days
27	Birmingham Birmingham	C+	48.3	3.4%	+0.0%	+0.9%	-1.3%	61 days
28	Oklahoma City Oklahoma City	C+	46.7	3.9%	+4.2%	+0.7%	-1.6%	57 days
29	Boston Boston-Cambridge-Newton	C+	45.0	3.9%	+2.9%	-0.1%	+2.9%	43 days
30	Portland Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro	C+	44.7	4.9%	+5.7%	-1.5%	+0.1%	66 days
31	Providence Providence-Warwick	C+	44.7	4.3%	+3.1%	+0.6%	+1.7%	39 days
32	Phoenix Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler	C+	44.6	4.9%	+3.3%	+0.9%	-2.9%	62 days
33	San Jose San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara	C	42.4	4.3%	-0.8%	+1.6%	-1.1%	35 days
34	Virginia Beach Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk	C	41.3	3.7%	+5.5%	-0.6%	-2.6%	44 days
35	New York New York Newark-Jersey City	C	39.9	4.7%	+1.9%	+0.5%	-0.1%	56 days
36	Minneapolis Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington	C	39.8	4.7%	+0.3%	+1.4%	-1.8%	42 days
37	Sacramento Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom	C	38.8	5.2%	+2.0%	+0.8%	-1.5%	51 days
38	San Diego San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad	C	38.7	4.9%	+7.5%	+0.7%	-2.1%	46 days
39	Milwaukee Milwaukee-Waukesha	C	38.0	3.8%	+0.5%	-0.2%	+1.6%	37 days
40	Denver Denver-Aurora-Centennial	C-	36.6	4.6%	+2.1%	+0.1%	-3.0%	58 days
41	Riverside Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario	C-	35.4	5.9%	+5.5%	+0.8%	-1.7%	64 days
42	Richmond Richmond	C-	35.3	3.6%	+2.4%	-0.8%	-2.6%	44 days
43	Memphis Memphis	C-	35.2	4.6%	+4.5%	-0.5%	-2.8%	72 days
44	Fresno Fresno	C-	33.8	7.8%	+4.5%	+0.8%	-1.3%	58 days
45	Indianapolis Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood	C-	32.1	3.3%	+0.6%	-1.1%	-1.9%	53 days
46	Jacksonville Jacksonville	C-	31.7	4.8%	+1.3%	+0.1%	-0.6%	66 days
47	Grand Rapids Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood	D	29.6	4.2%	+1.4%	+0.7%	-7.2%	42 days
48	Louisville Louisville-Jefferson County	D	28.7	4.1%	+1.7%	-0.1%	-0.8%	45 days
49	Chicago Chicago-Naperville-Elgin	D	26.4	5.2%	+3.3%	+0.2%	-3.1%	36 days
50	Detroit Detroit-Warren-Dearborn	D	19.0	5.7%	+1.5%	-0.2%	-1.8%	43 days

Salt Lake City

Salt Lake City-Murray

A

VERY GOOD

71.7th percentile

Rank 1 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 71.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a deep professional talent pool being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, scoring in the 90th percentile for both labor demand composite and office/professional worker share. The labor demand composite score of 7.39, driven by a 2.49% employment growth rate and a -0.398% weekly hours deviation, signals genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a city with a strong and growing economy.

Labor Demand

The Salt Lake City-Murray metro area has seen a 2.49% employment growth rate year-over-year, combined with a -0.398% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is adding jobs and that the existing workforce is not being overburdened, as hours are not significantly above trend. The labor demand composite score of 7.39 further reinforces this interpretation, placing the city in the top tier for labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Salt Lake City-Murray stands at 3.70%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 74th. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market, suggesting that businesses may face challenges in finding available talent and could experience upward pressure on wages. However, it also implies a stable and committed workforce.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Salt Lake City-Murray is +4.49%, ranking in the 64th percentile. This moderate to fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power. This balance is crucial for businesses considering relocation, as it affects both operational costs and the local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$262/sqft to \$39.26/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.67, Salt Lake City-Murray ranks in the 39th percentile for affordability, indicating that the city is less affordable compared to its peers. This relatively low affordability score means that attracting talent might require wage premiums to compensate for the higher cost of living, potentially increasing labor costs for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Salt Lake City-Murray has grown by +0.35% year-over-year, placing it in the 72nd percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests a growing pool of potential employees.

Building Permits

The city has seen a +28.20% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 84th percentile. This significant increase signals that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce, making it easier for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

Homes in Salt Lake City-Murray currently sit on the market for a median of 58 days, with a 0% year-over-year change. This stable and relatively fast market suggests that relocating workers may face a competitive environment when searching for housing, which could be a consideration for businesses in terms of relocation packages or support.

Office Economy

With an office/professional worker share composite score of 4.32, ranking in the 92nd percentile, Salt Lake City-Murray boasts a deep and talented professional pool. This makes the city highly suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those in industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Salt Lake City-Murray offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a growing and skilled workforce, and an expanding housing supply. However, the relatively low affordability and tight labor market, indicated by the 39th percentile cost of living rank and 3.70% unemployment rate, respectively, pose significant challenges that decision-makers must carefully consider, particularly in terms of wage premiums and talent attraction strategies.

Raleigh

Raleigh-Cary

A

VERY GOOD

70.7th percentile

Rank 2 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		98
25% weight		
Unemployment		94
20% weight		
Wage Growth		38
15% weight		
Cost of Living		82
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		36
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		36
10% weight		
Days on Market		36
5% weight		
Office Economy		98
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.1% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +2.2% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -5.7% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 59 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 70.7th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and low unemployment rate defining its current economic character, at 98th and 94th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 8.63, driven by a 2.23% employment growth rate and a 1.207% weekly hours deviation above trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This combination of metrics suggests a thriving job market.

Labor Demand

The Raleigh-Cary metro area has seen a 2.23% employment growth rate and a 1.207% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, indicating a strong labor demand. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, where jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 8.63 further reinforces this notion, placing the city in the top tier of labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Raleigh-Cary stands at 3.10%, which is in the top tier, indicating a tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The low unemployment rate also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Raleigh-Cary is 3.16%, which is below average, ranking in the 38th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to manage labor costs.

Cost of Living

Raleigh-Cary has a cost of living score that places it in the 82nd percentile, with a PSF of \$213/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$38.60/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.52. The fact that PSF is falling by 3.2% YoY relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can be a significant talent attraction factor, as workers may not require wage premiums to maintain their standard of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Raleigh-Cary has contracted by 1.63% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a structural headwind for hiring, as businesses may struggle to find available workers to fill open positions. The implications for hiring capacity are concerning, as the city's labor market may become increasingly competitive.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Raleigh-Cary has decreased by 5.68% year-over-year, signaling a tightening of housing supply. This decline in building permits may lead to a supply squeeze, potentially eroding future affordability and making it more challenging for workers to relocate to the city. The decrease in permits is a concern for businesses relying on a steady influx of new talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Raleigh-Cary is 59 days, with no year-over-year change. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing. However, the stable days on market suggests that the market is not overheating, and workers may still find opportunities to purchase or rent homes.

Office Economy

Raleigh-Cary has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 98th percentile. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require specialized knowledge-economy talent. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled workforce.

The Raleigh-Cary metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, low unemployment, and affordability, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply, which may lead to increased competition for talent and higher labor costs in the long run.

St. Louis

St. Louis

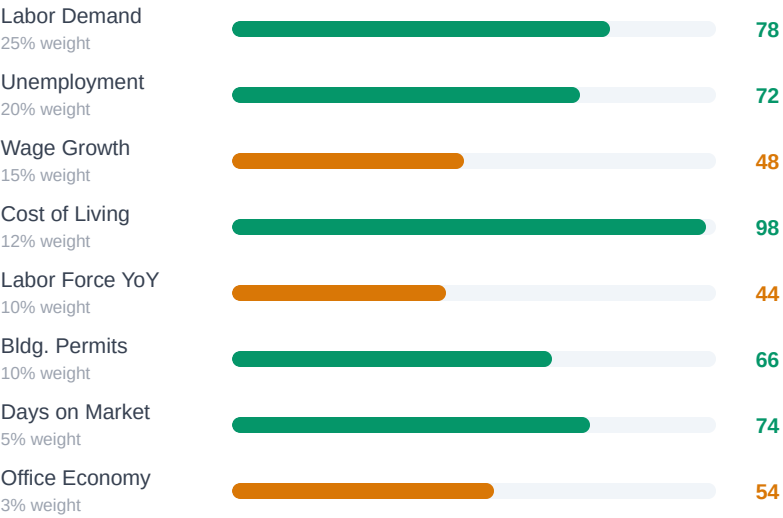
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VERY GOOD

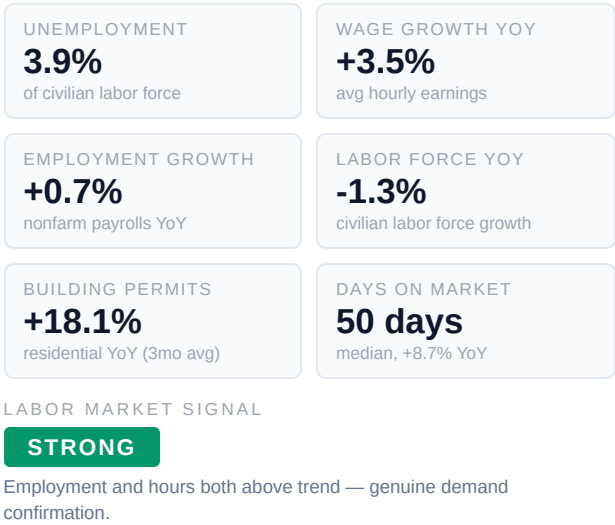
69.2th percentile

Rank 3 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

St. Louis earns an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and highly affordable cost of living being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, at 78th and 98th percentiles, respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.44 and cost of living ratio of 4.28, with PSF at \$163/sqft and hourly earnings at \$38.11, signal a unique combination of job growth and affordability. With these metrics, St. Louis presents an attractive environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in St. Louis is +0.68% year-over-year, combined with a +1.193% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 6.44 further supports this interpretation, ranking in the 78th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in St. Louis is 3.90%, which is above average, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the practical implication is that while it may be slightly harder to find candidates than in cities with higher unemployment rates, the market is not excessively tight, allowing for manageable hiring processes. This balance suggests a stable environment for workforce planning.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in St. Louis is +3.51%, which is near the median, ranking in the 48th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that employer labor costs are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while worker purchasing power is also growing, albeit not exceptionally fast. The moderate wage growth environment means that businesses can expect stable labor costs without significant pressure to increase wages dramatically.

Cost of Living

St. Louis is highly affordable, with a cost of living percentile rank of 98th, driven by a PSF of \$163/sqft that is decreasing by -1.8% year-over-year, compared to hourly earnings of \$38.11, resulting in a ratio of 4.28. This high affordability ranking means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can enjoy a high standard of living without requiring wage premiums to compensate for expensive housing.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in St. Louis is growing at a rate of -1.33% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor supply. This negative growth rate implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking, which could lead to increased competition for talent and potentially higher wages over time.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in St. Louis has increased by +18.07% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in housing supply. This increase in building permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to improve, which should help maintain or improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in St. Louis is 50 days, with an 8.7% year-over-year increase, indicating a slightly slower market. For a worker relocating to this city, the increasing days on market suggest a more accessible and less competitive housing market, making it easier to find and purchase a home.

Office Economy

St. Louis has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 54th percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a notable presence of professional and office roles, but it may not be the ideal location for businesses requiring an exceptionally deep pool of specialized tech, finance, or consulting talent.

In conclusion, St. Louis offers businesses a unique blend of strong labor demand, high affordability, and moderate wage growth, making it an attractive location for expansion or relocation. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the contracting labor force, which could lead to future hiring challenges and increased labor costs, necessitating strategic workforce planning and talent attraction strategies.

Las Vegas

Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas

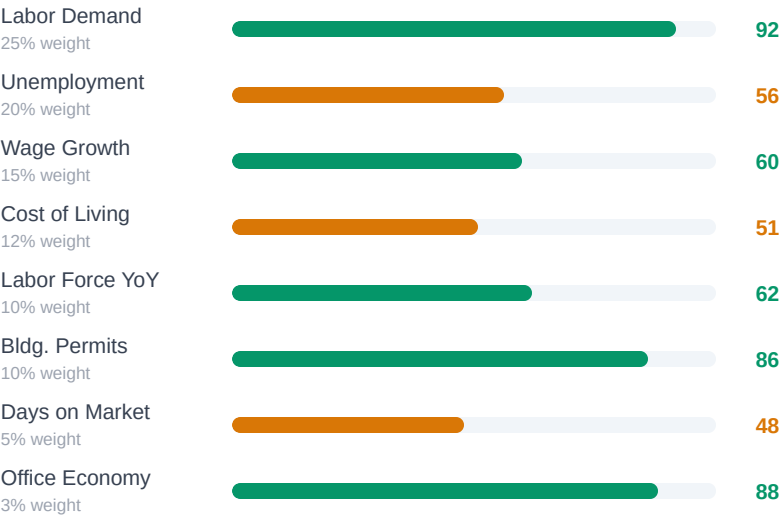
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VERY GOOD

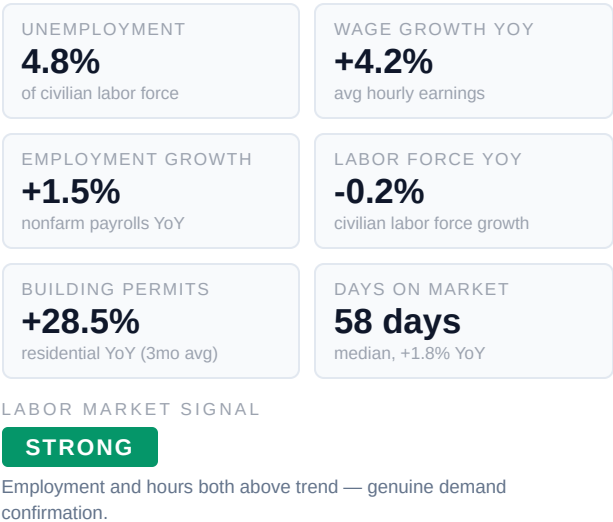
69.2th percentile

Rank 4 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 69.2th percentile among 50 US metros, with a strong labor demand and a thriving office economy being the two metrics that most define its current economic character, driven by a 92th percentile labor demand composite score and an 88th percentile office/professional worker share. The city's labor market is characterized by a 1.46% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.098% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 1.46% and weekly hours deviation of 1.098% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This signals that the city is experiencing an increase in job opportunities and workers are putting in more hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 7.44, ranking in the 92th percentile, further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is 4.80%, ranking in the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in finding the right talent. However, the current unemployment rate suggests that there is still a pool of available workers for businesses to tap into.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the city is 4.21%, ranking in the 60th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This means that employer labor costs are rising, but at a manageable rate, and workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth suggests that businesses can expect to pay slightly higher wages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas is near median, with a percentile rank of 51, and a price-to-salary ratio of \$259/sqft to \$33.35/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.77. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.0% year-over-year is a key driver of the city's affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to relocate without having to offer significant wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the city is growing at a rate of -0.21% year-over-year, ranking in the 62nd percentile, indicating a slight contraction in the labor force supply. This means that the pool of available workers is shrinking, which could pose a structural headwind for hiring in the future. However, the relatively slow rate of contraction suggests that businesses can still find talent, albeit with some effort.

Building Permits

The city is experiencing a 28.53% year-over-year increase in residential building permits, ranking in the 86th percentile, indicating a significant expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and the future housing supply is expected to increase, which could lead to improved affordability and a more attractive environment for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 58 days, with a year-over-year increase of 1.8%, ranking in the 48th percentile. This indicates a relatively competitive market, but one that is still accessible for relocating workers. The slow increase in days on market suggests that the market is normalizing, making it easier for workers to find homes.

Office Economy

The city has a deep professional talent pool, with an office/professional worker share of 3.86, ranking in the 88th percentile. This makes it an attractive location for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas metro area offers businesses a strong labor market, a thriving office economy, and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for relocation or expansion. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the slight contraction in the labor force supply, which could pose challenges for hiring in the future.

Charlotte

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia

A-

GOOD

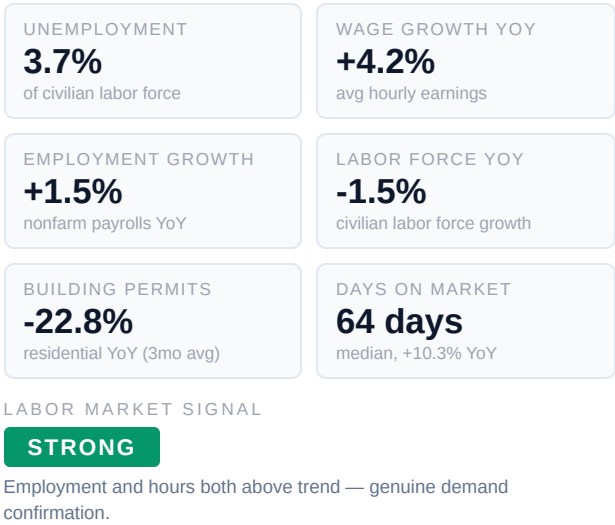
68.0th percentile

Rank 5 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 68.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 96th percentile, driven by a 1.54% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.361% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. The combination of these metrics signals genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area is experiencing a significant expansion in labor demand, with a 1.54% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 1.361% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a sign of a healthy and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 7.82 ranks in the top tier at the 96th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.70%, ranking in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 4.22%, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can have a positive impact on local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has a cost of living score that ranks above average at the 78th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$217/sqft to \$38.91/hr, or 5.58. The fact that the PSF is falling by 1.4% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can maintain a relatively high standard of living without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is shrinking at a rate of -1.49% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia has decreased by 22.75% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile. This sharp decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is currently 64 days, with a year-over-year increase of 10.3%. This ranks in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile, indicating a slower market. For workers relocating to the city, this means that the housing market is relatively accessible, with homes taking longer to sell.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia is 3.66, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. The city is well-suited for knowledge-economy businesses but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia metro area offers businesses a strong labor demand and a talented workforce, making it an attractive location for companies in the knowledge economy. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract and retain workers.

Austin

Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos

A

VERY GOOD

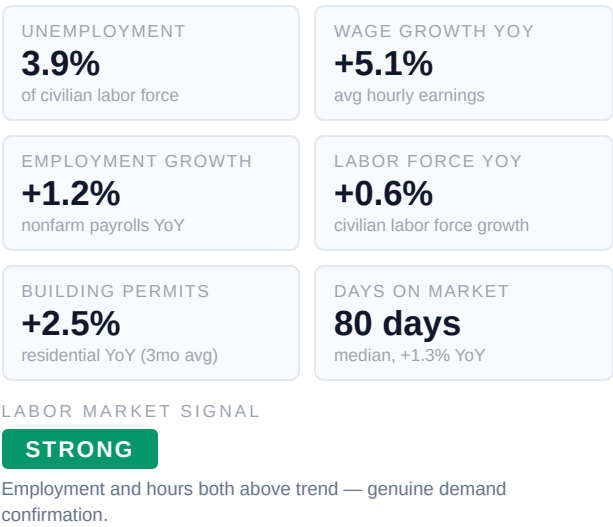
68.0th percentile

Rank 6 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos metro area has earned an overall grade of A, ranking in the 68.0th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven significantly by its top-tier labor demand and cost of living metrics, scoring 80th and 96th percentiles respectively. The city's labor demand composite score of 6.59, combining a +1.16% employment growth rate and a +0.667% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals a genuine demand expansion. This, coupled with its highly affordable cost of living, makes Austin an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Austin stands at +1.16% year-over-year, accompanied by a +0.667% deviation in weekly hours above its own 12-month trend, indicating a strong and genuine demand for labor. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth where hours are also increasing, pointing to a healthy expansion of economic activity rather than a survivor squeeze. The labor demand composite score of 6.59 further reinforces this, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile.

Unemployment

Austin's unemployment rate is 3.90%, placing it near the median at the 46th percentile. This rate suggests that while the market is not extremely tight, it does have some slack, making it somewhat easier for businesses to hire compared to cities with lower unemployment rates. However, the relatively low unemployment rate still implies some level of competition for talent, which could lead to moderate wage pressure.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Austin is +5.08%, which is above average, ranking in the 70th percentile. This level of wage growth indicates that labor costs for employers are rising, but it also means that workers have increasing purchasing power, which can be beneficial for local consumer demand. The wage growth suggests a dynamic labor market where employers may need to adjust their compensation packages to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 6.01, derived from \$228/sqft (which has decreased by 8.4% year-over-year) compared to average hourly earnings of \$37.93, Austin ranks in the top tier for affordability at the 96th percentile. This high affordability score means that the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without the need for substantial wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively low compared to earnings.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Austin is growing at a rate of +0.64% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the city's hiring capacity is not constrained by a shrinking labor pool, providing businesses with a growing talent base from which to recruit.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Austin has increased by +2.50% year-over-year, signaling a modest expansion in housing supply. Although this growth is only at the 50th percentile, it suggests that developer confidence is present, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which can help maintain affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Austin are currently sitting on the market for a median of 80 days, with a year-over-year increase of +1.3%. This situation, ranking in the 20th percentile, indicates a relatively fast-paced market that may be challenging for relocating workers, as homes are selling quickly. However, this also suggests a strong demand for housing, which can be a sign of a vibrant local economy.

Office Economy

Austin's professional and office worker share is ranked in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating a deep and specialized talent pool. This makes the city particularly well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for those primarily involved in industrial or logistics activities.

In conclusion, Austin offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, highly affordable cost of living, and a deep professional talent pool, making it an attractive location for a variety of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the potential for housing market pressures, given the relatively fast-paced sales environment, which could impact the affordability and attractiveness of the city for relocating workers over time.

Hartford

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford

A-

GOOD

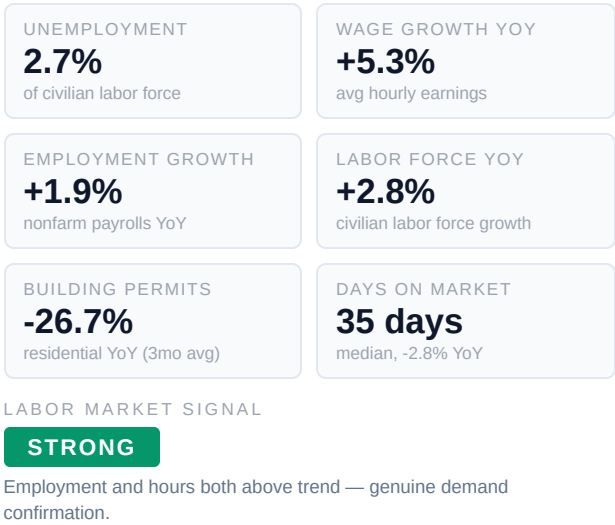
67.1th percentile

Rank 7 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 67.1th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 86th percentile, and its extremely low unemployment rate of 2.70%, ranking it at the 98th percentile. The combination of these two metrics suggests a highly competitive job market with genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +1.88% year-over-year, combined with a +0.025% deviation in weekly hours from its own trend, signaling genuine demand expansion. This indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The top-tier composite score of 86th percentile further reinforces this trend.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 2.70%, ranking it at the 98th percentile, indicating an extremely tight labor market. This means that there is very little slack in the market, making it challenging for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is +5.30%, ranking it at the 74th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising, but workers will also have increased purchasing power. While this may be a challenge for businesses, it also indicates a strong and growing local economy.

Cost of Living

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has a cost of living score ranking it at the 24th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The city's PSF of \$250/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$40.19/hr result in a ratio of 6.22, which is below average. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is growing at a rate of +2.77% year-over-year, ranking it at the 96th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire, as it suggests that there will be a growing pool of potential employees to draw from.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has decreased by -26.73% year-over-year, ranking it at the 10th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This suggests that the city may face future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges, which could impact its ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford is 35 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.8%, ranking it at the 12th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast-paced and competitive housing market, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find affordable housing.

Office Economy

Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford has an office economy score ranking it at the 26th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow professional talent pool. This suggests that the city may be better suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on office or professional workers, such as industrial or logistics companies.

The Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford metro area offers businesses a highly competitive job market with strong labor demand and low unemployment, but also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and relatively high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the tightening housing supply, which could impact affordability and workforce accommodation in the future.

Cincinnati

Cincinnati

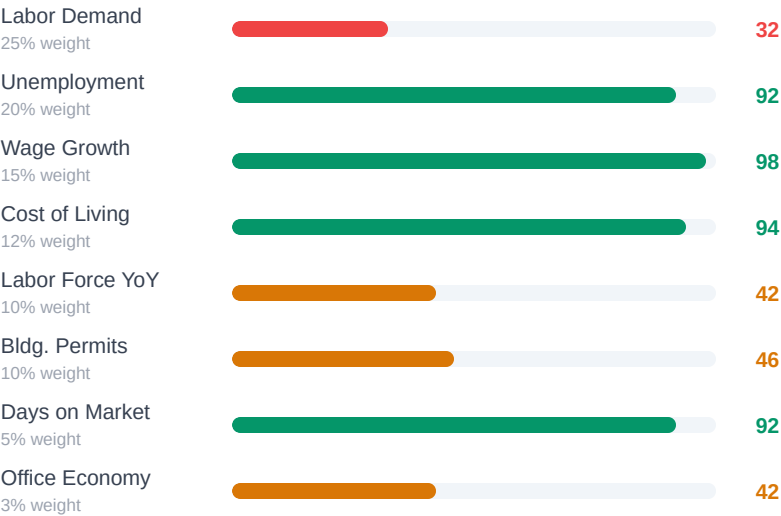
A-

GOOD

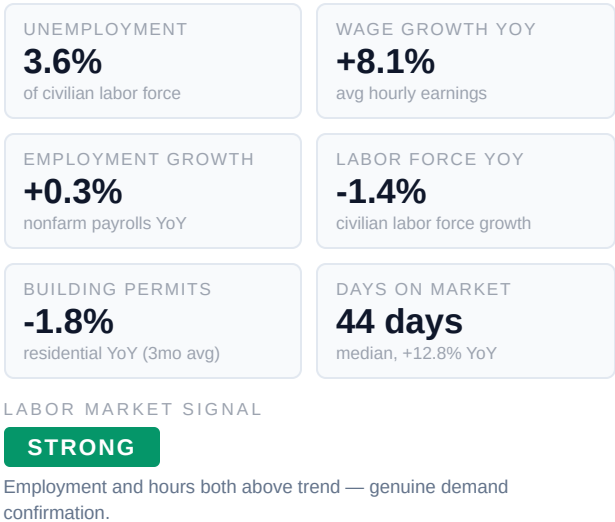
67.0th percentile

Rank 8 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Cincinnati metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking it at the 67.0th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its exceptionally low unemployment rate of 3.60% and its strong wage growth of +8.11% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The combination of these metrics suggests that Cincinnati is an attractive location for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce.

Labor Demand

Cincinnati's employment growth rate is +0.31% year-over-year, and its weekly hours deviation from trend is +0.000%, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 4.73, which ranks below average at the 32nd percentile. This combination signals a moderate expansion of genuine demand, as the city is adding jobs, albeit at a slow pace. However, the negligible hours deviation suggests that the existing workforce is not being overutilized.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cincinnati is 3.60%, ranking at the 92nd percentile, indicating a very tight labor market with minimal slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, potentially driving up wage costs. As a result, employers may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain top performers.

Wage Growth

Cincinnati's year-over-year wage growth rate is +8.11%, ranking at the 98th percentile, which is exceptionally high. This rapid wage growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but it also translates to strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, but they can also expect a highly productive and skilled workforce.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$190/sqft to \$36.31/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.23, Cincinnati ranks at the 94th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.0% year-over-year further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cincinnati is contracting at a rate of -1.35% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it essential for businesses to invest in talent retention and development strategies.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Cincinnati is -1.83%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Cincinnati is 44 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.8%, ranking at the 92nd percentile. This indicates a slower market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also suggest a normalization of the market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Cincinnati's professional and office worker share ranks near the median at the 42nd percentile, indicating a moderately deep talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a mix of professional and industrial skills, but it may not be the best fit for companies that rely heavily on specialized tech or finance talent.

In conclusion, Cincinnati offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and relatively low cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to tap into a skilled and productive workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the declining labor force supply, which may require businesses to invest in talent retention and development strategies to mitigate the impact of a shrinking labor pool.

Philadelphia

Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington

A-

GOOD

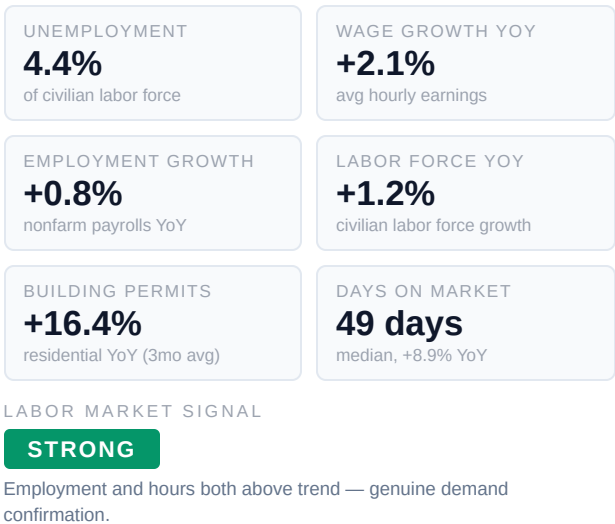
65.9th percentile

Rank 9 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area has earned an overall grade of A- with a composite score ranking in the 65.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 84th percentile, driven by employment growth of 0.83% year-over-year and weekly hours 1.3% above its own 12-month trend. The combination of these metrics signals genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.83% year-over-year and weekly hours deviation of 1.3% above trend indicate a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and working hours, which is a positive indicator for businesses looking to expand or relocate. The labor demand composite score of 6.76, ranking in the 84th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington is 4.4%, ranking in the 76th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly challenging for businesses to hire, the market is not overly competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively low unemployment rate implies that they may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of 2.14% is below average, ranking in the 26th percentile, indicating stagnant to moderate wage growth. This implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong bargaining power either.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of 7.00, where the price per square foot is \$228 and average hourly earnings are \$32.59, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington ranks in the 41st percentile, indicating a near-median affordability level. The fact that the price per square foot is decreasing by 0.9% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 1.23% year-over-year, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This means that the city has a growing pool of potential employees, which can facilitate hiring and reduce the risk of labor

shortages. As a result, businesses can expect a relatively favorable hiring environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is 16.37%, ranking in the 64th percentile, indicating an expansion of housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city is likely to experience improving affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce. As a result, businesses can expect a relatively stable and expanding housing market, which can support their growth plans.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 49 days, with a year-over-year increase of 8.9%, ranking in the 78th percentile. This indicates a relatively slow market, which can be accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market also suggests that the market may be normalizing, which can be a positive sign for businesses looking to attract talent.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 2.86, ranking in the 60th percentile, Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington has a relatively deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This city is well-suited for businesses that require specialized knowledge-economy roles, but may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington metro area offers businesses a strong labor market with genuine demand expansion, a relatively tight labor market, and a near-median affordability level. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively slow wage growth, which may limit worker purchasing power and bargaining power, potentially affecting businesses that rely on a highly skilled and motivated workforce.

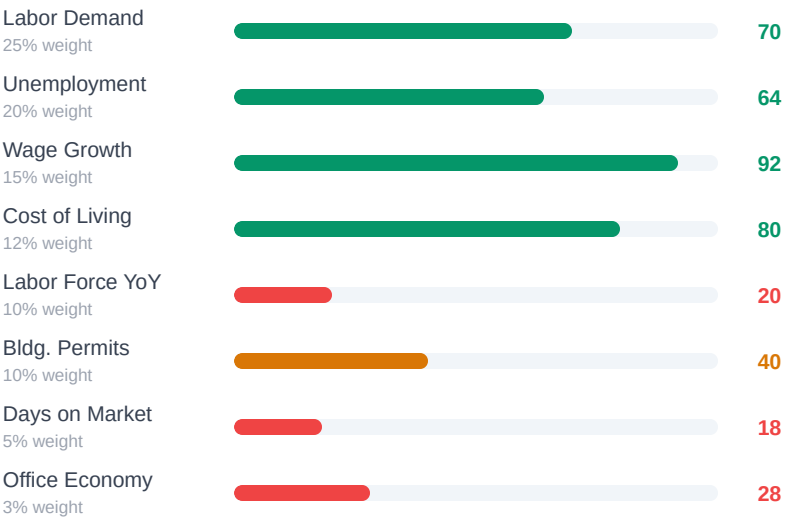
Kansas City

Kansas City

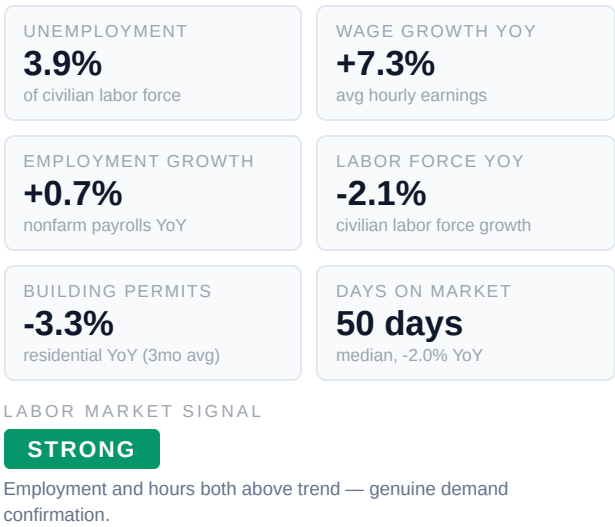
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
61.4th percentile
Rank 10 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Kansas City has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.4th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 7.35%, and its labor demand composite score of 5.99, which ranks in the 70th percentile. These metrics suggest a city with a robust job market and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

Kansas City's employment growth rate of 0.73% and weekly hours deviation of 0.665% above its own trend signal genuine demand expansion, indicating that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours. This combination suggests a healthy labor market with increasing demand for workers. The labor demand composite score of 5.99, ranking in the 70th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.90% ranks in the 64th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight market implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of 7.35%, Kansas City is experiencing fast wage growth, ranking in the 92nd percentile. This rapid growth implies rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to budget for higher labor costs, while workers will have more disposable income to spend in the local economy.

Cost of Living

Kansas City's cost of living, with a PSF of \$195/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.36, ranks in the 80th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. This affordability advantage can attract talent without requiring wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to hire and retain workers.

Labor Force Growth

The city's labor force growth rate of -2.09% indicates that the supply of workers is contracting, ranking in the 20th percentile. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the shrinking labor pool may limit the availability of skilled workers. Businesses may need to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits of -3.34% suggests that housing supply is tightening, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This tightening of supply may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing, potentially affecting the city's ability to attract and retain workers.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 50 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.0%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This fast-paced market means that homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. Businesses may need to offer relocation assistance or flexible housing options to attract talent.

Office Economy

Kansas City's professional and office worker share ranks in the 28th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. The city is less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more attractive to industries with different skill requirements.

In conclusion, Kansas City offers a strong job market with rising labor costs, making it an attractive location for businesses that can adapt to these conditions. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the contracting labor force, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and require businesses to invest in training and development programs to attract and retain talent.

Dallas

Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
61.3th percentile
Rank 11 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		82
Unemployment 20% weight		36
Wage Growth 15% weight		54
Cost of Living 12% weight		88
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		78
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		20
Days on Market 5% weight		46
Office Economy 3% weight		94

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +4.0% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.0% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -15.9% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 62 days median, -1.6% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 61.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a top-tier composite score of 82th percentile, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 88th percentile. The combination of these two metrics signals a city with genuine demand expansion and a talent attraction advantage.

Labor Demand

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area has seen employment growth of +1.00% year-over-year, combined with a +0.903% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 6.60 further reinforces this interpretation, indicating a strong and growing job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington stands at 4.40%, ranking at the 36th percentile, indicating a market with some slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may have an easier time finding candidates, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The relatively high unemployment rate compared to other metros suggests that the labor market is not overly tight.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is +4.03%, ranking near the median at the 54th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. The wage growth rate is not exceptionally high, but it is still positive, indicating a relatively stable labor cost environment.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$198/sqft to \$38.10/hr, and a year-over-year decline of -2.5% in PSF, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is a highly affordable city, ranked at the 88th percentile. This means that the city has a significant talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford a high quality of life without requiring excessive wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has grown by +0.62% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in the area. The growing labor force suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential employees.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has declined by -15.89% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 20th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The decline in building permits is a concern for future workforce accommodation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington is 62 days, with a year-over-year decline of -1.6%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, although the decline in days on market is modest. For workers relocating to this city, the market is still relatively competitive, but not excessively so.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share ranked at the 94th percentile, Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington has a deep and talented pool of knowledge-economy workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a skilled and professional workforce.

The Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand, affordable cost of living, and a deep talent pool, making it an attractive location for companies in the knowledge-economy sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability challenges and make it more difficult to attract and retain workers.

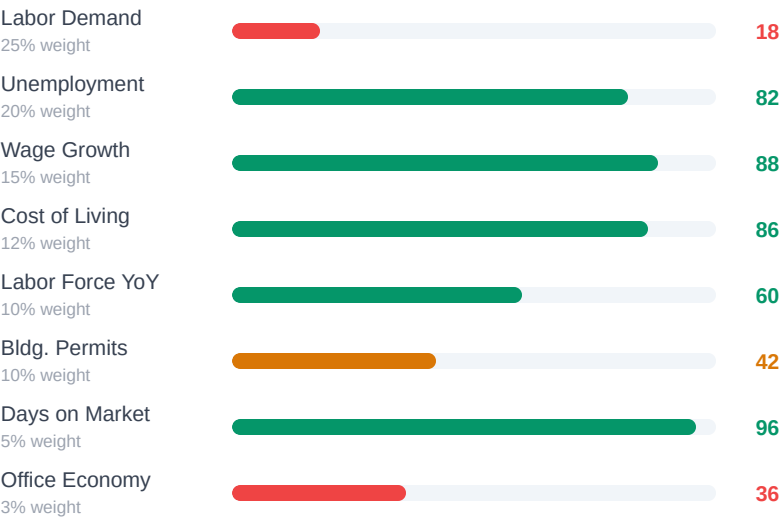
Baltimore

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson

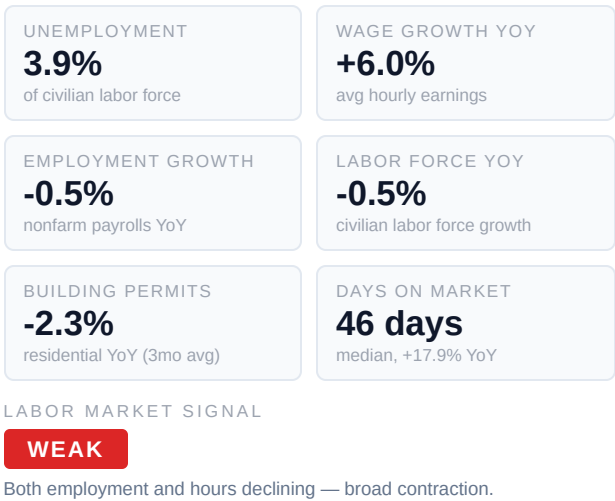
B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
60.5th percentile
Rank 12 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area has an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.5th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and strong wage growth of +5.99% year-over-year, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging hiring environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is -0.47% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating -0.175% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 3.64, which ranks in the bottom tier at the 18th percentile. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job growth and hours worked. This scenario suggests that businesses may face a less competitive environment for talent.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent, leading to potential wage pressure and hiring challenges. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries and benefits to attract and retain employees.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is +5.99%, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating fast-rising labor costs for employers. This strong wage growth is good for worker purchasing power, as employees will have more disposable income to spend on goods and services. However, it also means that businesses will face increasing labor costs, which may impact their bottom line.

Cost of Living

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has a cost of living score ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile, with a PSF of \$215/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.96, resulting in a ratio of 5.66. The city's PSF is also falling by -2.7% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to peers. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live and work in the area without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is growing at a rate of -0.45% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 60th percentile. This indicates that the labor force supply is contracting, which may pose a structural headwind for hiring in the city. As a result, businesses may need to consider strategies to attract and retain talent from outside the area.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is decreasing by -2.34% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 42nd percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability challenges and impact the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Baltimore-Columbia-Towson is currently 46 days, with a year-over-year increase of +17.9%, ranking in the top tier at the 96th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are taking longer to sell, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market, rather than a decline in demand.

Office Economy

Baltimore-Columbia-Towson has an office economy score ranking below average at the 36th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.14 out of 5. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool for tech, finance, and consulting businesses, but may be more suited for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Baltimore-Columbia-Towson metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, strong wage growth, and a relatively affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's contracting labor force supply, which may pose significant challenges for hiring and talent retention in the long term.

Orlando

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford

B+

ABOVE AVERAGE
60.3th percentile
Rank 13 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		72
Unemployment 20% weight		24
Wage Growth 15% weight		90
Cost of Living 12% weight		71
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		74
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		22
Days on Market 5% weight		62
Office Economy 3% weight		90

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.6%	WAGE GROWTH YOY +6.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.8%	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.4% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) -15.7%	DAYS ON MARKET 77 days median, -2.5% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has earned an overall grade of B+ with a composite score ranking it at the 60.3th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the 72nd percentile, and its top-tier wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 6.12%. These metrics signal a city with a growing economy and rising labor costs.

Labor Demand

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area has seen employment growth of 0.80% year-over-year, combined with a 0.783% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This indicates that the local economy is experiencing a real increase in labor demand, rather than just a redistribution of existing work.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 4.60%, which ranks in the 24th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers without facing intense competition. However, this also implies that local consumer demand may be weaker due to the higher unemployment rate.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 6.12%, ranking in the 90th percentile, which is a top-tier performance. This fast wage growth means that labor costs are rising quickly for employers, but it also gives workers more purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and motivated workforce.

Cost of Living

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a cost of living score in the 71st percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$222/sqft to \$34.05/hr, or 6.52. The fact that the PSF is falling by 3.1% year-over-year relative to wages makes the city more affordable. This affordability advantage can help attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums, making it an attractive location for businesses.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is growing at a rate of 0.38% year-over-year, which is above average and ranks in the 74th percentile. This expansion in the labor force supply means that businesses have a growing pool of potential workers to hire from, which can support their growth plans.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has decreased by 15.65% year-over-year, which is below average and ranks in the 22nd percentile. This decline in building permits signals that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford is 77 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 2.5%. This relatively fast market means that workers relocating to the city may face competition for housing, making it challenging to find a place to live quickly.

Office Economy

Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking in the 90th percentile. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that require a highly skilled and specialized workforce. However, it may be less suitable for industries that rely on industrial or logistics workers.

The Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford metro area offers businesses a growing economy with a strong labor demand and rising wages, making it an attractive location for companies that value a highly skilled and motivated workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce, potentially offsetting the benefits of the city's economic growth.

Pittsburgh

Pittsburgh

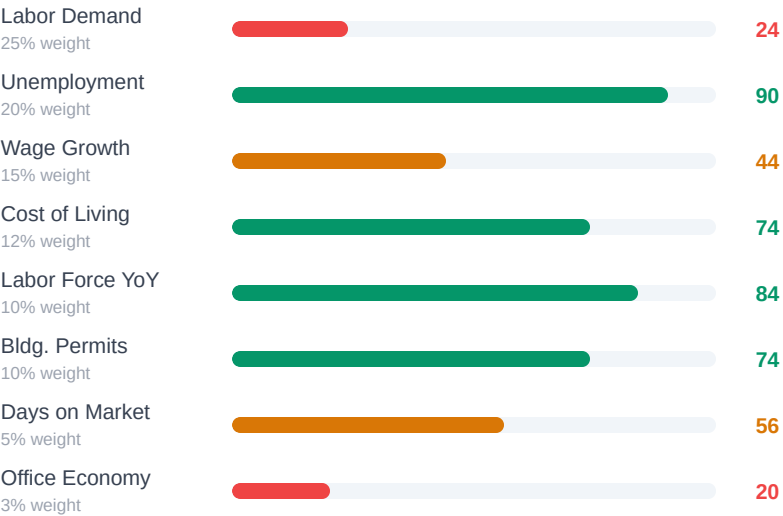
B

AVERAGE

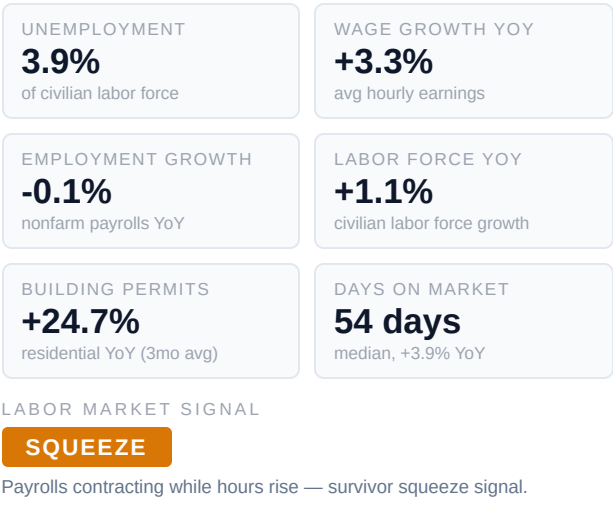
58.6th percentile

Rank 14 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Pittsburgh earns an overall grade of B, ranking 58.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its low unemployment rate of 3.90% and a cost of living score that indicates relative affordability. The city's labor demand composite score of 4.06, combining a -0.05% employment growth rate and a +0.173% weekly hours deviation, suggests a mixed signal. The low unemployment rate and moderate wage growth are key defining characteristics of Pittsburgh's current economic landscape.

Labor Demand

Pittsburgh's employment growth rate is -0.05%, indicating a slight contraction, while weekly hours are running +0.173% above trend, suggesting some level of demand. However, the combination of these two metrics signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. This mixed signal warrants caution for businesses considering location decisions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Pittsburgh is 3.90%, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile, indicating a very tight labor market. This tight market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure likely. For a business trying to hire in Pittsburgh, the low unemployment rate implies a competitive environment for talent acquisition.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Pittsburgh is +3.33% year-over-year, placing it near the median at the 44th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively, while workers are experiencing some improvement in purchasing power. The implication is a relatively stable cost environment for businesses, with workers having moderate bargaining power.

Cost of Living

Pittsburgh's cost of living, with a PSF of \$170/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$33.44, results in a ratio of 5.08, ranking above average at the 74th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively more affordable compared to its peers, which can be a significant talent attraction advantage without necessitating wage premiums. The -1.2% year-over-year decrease in PSF relative to wages further enhances the city's affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Pittsburgh is growing at a rate of +1.07% year-over-year, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive growth rate suggests that the hiring capacity for businesses is improving, as there are more potential workers entering the labor market. This trend is beneficial for companies looking to expand their operations in the city.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Pittsburgh are increasing by +24.71% year-over-year, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is high, and the city is likely to see improvements in affordability and an easier time accommodating a growing workforce. The increasing supply of housing will help mitigate potential workforce attraction challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Pittsburgh is 54 days, with a year-over-year increase of +3.9%. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be beneficial for workers relocating to the city, as it may provide them with more options and less competitive pressure. However, the market remains relatively competitive, and relocating workers should still anticipate a brisk sales environment.

Office Economy

Pittsburgh's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 20th percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other cities. This suggests that Pittsburgh is less suited for businesses requiring a large pool of tech, finance, or consulting talent but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs, such as manufacturing or logistics.

In conclusion, Pittsburgh offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market, moderate wage growth, and relative affordability, making it an attractive location for certain types of industries. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the city's below-average labor demand and office economy metrics, which may limit its appeal for businesses heavily reliant on professional and office sectors.

Seattle

Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue

B

AVERAGE

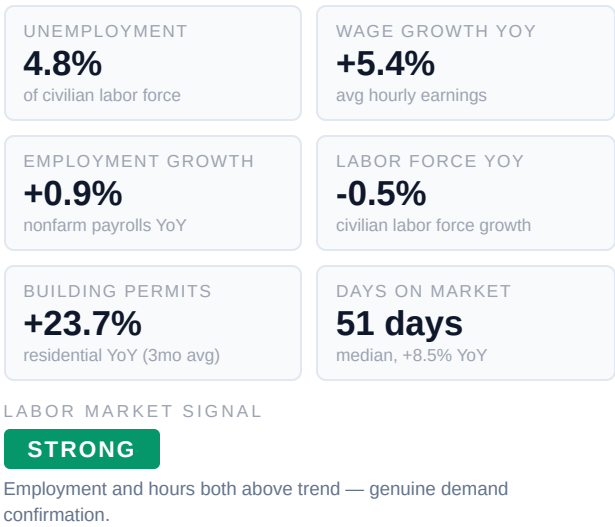
57.6th percentile

Rank 15 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area has an overall grade of B, ranking in the 57.6th percentile among 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its above-average labor demand and strong wage growth, at 66th and 76th percentiles, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, which signal a growing economy with increasing labor costs. With employment growth at 0.88% year-over-year and weekly hours 0.406% above trend, the city is experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Labor Demand

The combination of 0.88% employment growth and 0.406% above-trend weekly hours signals genuine demand expansion in the Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area. This indicates that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, suggesting a strong and growing economy. The labor demand composite score of 5.94, at the 66th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 4.80%, which is below average, ranking at the 28th percentile. This tight labor market means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as well as upward pressure on wages. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract and retain talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 5.44%, which is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This rapid wage growth implies increasing labor costs for employers, but also strong purchasing power for workers. As a result, businesses may need to factor in rising labor costs, while also benefiting from a workforce with increasing disposable income.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$427/sqft to \$48.08/hr, and a year-over-year decrease of 2.5% in PSF, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a near-median affordability score, ranking at the 45th percentile. This means that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without requiring significant wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a key driver of this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is shrinking at a rate of -0.54% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 58th percentile. This contraction in labor supply may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their recruitment strategies to attract talent from a shrinking labor force.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has increased by 23.71% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This surge in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce. As a result, the city may become more attractive to relocating workers and businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue is 51 days, with an 8.5% year-over-year increase, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates a slowing market, where homes are taking longer to sell. For workers relocating to the city, this may mean a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

With an office and professional worker share of 3.08, ranking at the 74th percentile, Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue has a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. The city's strong office economy makes it an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue metro area offers businesses a growing economy with a strong labor market and increasing wages, making it an attractive location for companies in the tech and professional services sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tight labor market, which may drive up labor costs and pose challenges in hiring and retaining talent.

Tampa

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
54.8th percentile
Rank 16 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		60
25% weight		
Unemployment		16
20% weight		
Wage Growth		72
15% weight		
Cost of Living		84
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		70
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		30
10% weight		
Days on Market		66
5% weight		
Office Economy		82
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.7% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +5.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.9% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -10.1% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 76 days median, -3.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score of 5.71, and its top-tier cost of living, with a percentile rank of 84th. The labor demand is driven by a combination of employment growth and hours worked above trend, while the cost of living is influenced by a PSF to earnings ratio of 6.22, with PSF decreasing by 6.1% year-over-year.

Labor Demand

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.92% year-over-year and a weekly hours deviation of 0.120% above its own trend. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. The labor demand composite score of 5.71 is above average, ranking at the 60th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 4.70%, ranking at the 16th percentile, indicating a relatively loose labor market. This means that there is some slack in the market, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the relatively high unemployment rate also suggests weaker local consumer demand.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 5.13%, ranking above average at the 72nd percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which will lead to rising labor costs for employers. On the other hand, workers will benefit from increased purchasing power, making the city more attractive to talent.

Cost of Living

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a cost of living percentile rank of 84th, indicating that it is more affordable relative to its peers. The PSF to earnings ratio of 6.22, with PSF decreasing by 6.1% year-over-year, makes the city an attractive destination for talent without requiring significant wage premiums. This is a major advantage for businesses looking to relocate or expand in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is growing at a rate of 0.34% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force will provide a larger pool of potential workers, making it easier to find talent.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has decreased by 10.10% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 30th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decrease in building permits is a concern for businesses that rely on a steady supply of housing for their workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater is 76 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 3.8%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, making it competitive for workers relocating to the city. The decrease in days on market suggests that the housing market is still active, but the relatively low days on market may make it challenging for workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 82nd. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may not be as suitable for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors, which require a different type of workforce.

The Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and a highly affordable cost of living. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the tightening housing supply, which may lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. This could offset some of the advantages of locating in the area, and businesses should carefully consider this factor when making their decision.

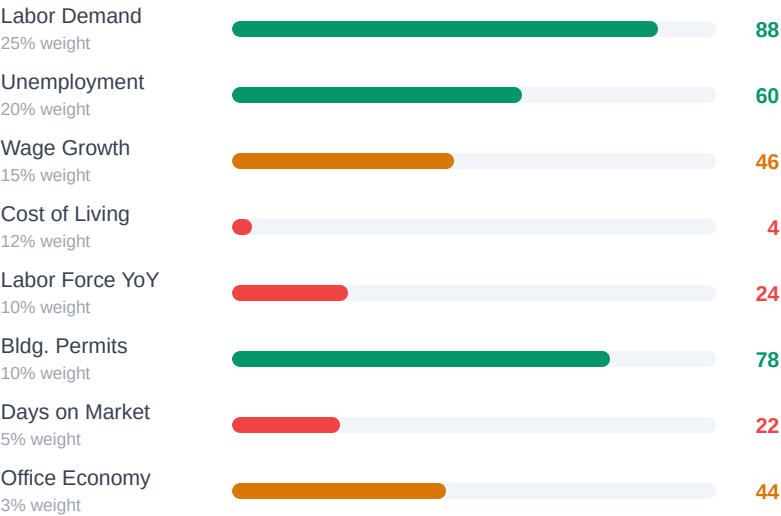
Los Angeles

Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim

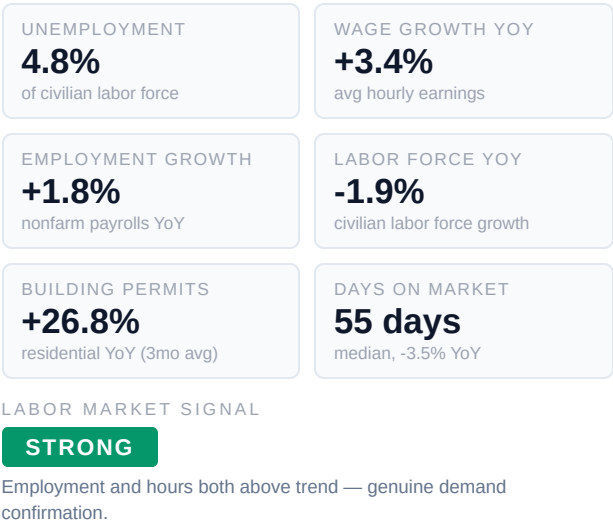
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
54.0th percentile
Rank 17 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 54.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor demand, with a composite score in the top tier at the 88th percentile, and its high cost of living, ranked at the 4th percentile. The labor demand is driven by a 1.83% year-over-year employment growth rate and a 0.151% deviation in weekly hours above its own trend.

Labor Demand

The combination of a 1.83% employment growth rate and a 0.151% increase in weekly hours above trend signals genuine demand expansion in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area. This indicates that the city is experiencing a period of job growth, with hours worked also increasing, suggesting a strong and vibrant labor market. The labor demand composite score of 7.01 further reinforces this, ranking in the top tier at the 88th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 4.80%, ranking at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that while it may be slightly challenging to find the right talent, it is still possible to attract workers without excessive wage pressure. However, the market is not so loose that it would be easy to find qualified candidates at low wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 3.39%, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but not at an alarming rate, while workers are seeing some improvement in their purchasing power. This balance is generally favorable for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still attracting and retaining talent.

Cost of Living

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a cost of living ranked at the 4th percentile, with a price per square foot of \$647 and average hourly earnings of \$41.54, resulting in a ratio of 15.58. This makes the city one of the more expensive places to live relative to peers, which can be a significant disadvantage for talent attraction, as businesses may need to offer wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is contracting at a rate of -1.91% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 24th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply implies that the hiring capacity for businesses may be limited, making it more challenging to find and recruit new talent, potentially leading to increased competition for workers and upward pressure on wages.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is +26.84%, ranking above average at the 78th percentile. This significant increase in building permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area is 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.5%, ranking below average at the 22nd percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find and purchase homes, potentially affecting their decision to move to the area.

Office Economy

The Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area has a professional and office worker share ranked near the median at the 44th percentile, with a composite score of 2.32. This suggests that while the city has a notable presence of professional and office sectors, it is not as deep as in some other metros, making it more suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy, rather than those requiring a highly specialized or abundant professional talent pool.

In conclusion, the Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim metro area offers a strong labor demand and expanding housing supply, which could support business growth and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the high cost of living, which may necessitate offering wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs and affecting profitability.

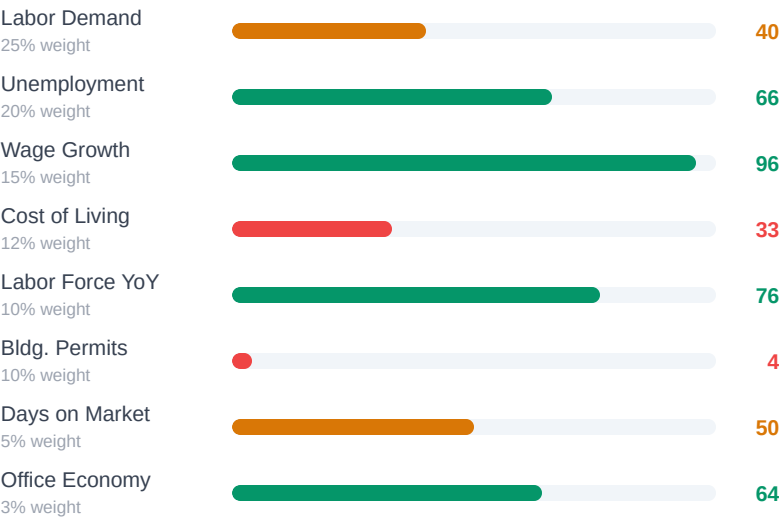
Miami

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach

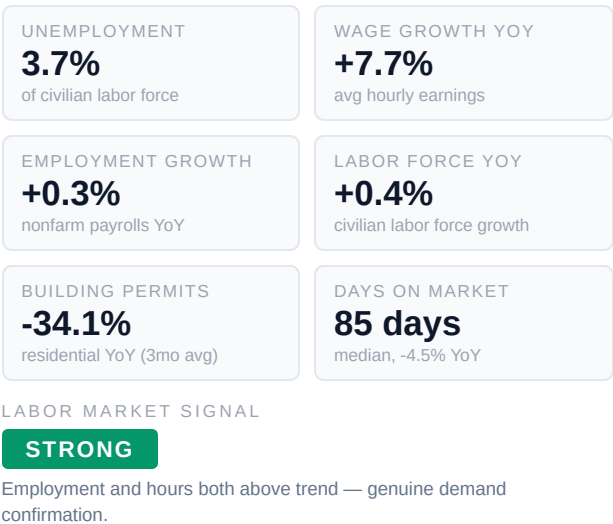
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
53.9th percentile
Rank 18 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 53.9th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 7.68% year-over-year and its low cost of living percentile rank of 33, indicating a relatively expensive city. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses to balance labor costs and talent attraction.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 0.35% year-over-year, accompanied by a 0.285% deviation in weekly hours above the city's own trend. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one, as both jobs and hours are increasing. The labor demand composite score of 5.08 ranks near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a stable but not exceptional labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 3.70%, ranking at the 66th percentile, which indicates a relatively tight labor market. This tightness implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The practical implication is that companies may experience more wage pressure in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 7.68%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which is exceptionally high. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers but also indicates strong worker purchasing power. Businesses should be prepared for increasing labor expenses, but the high wages can also attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has a cost of living percentile rank of 33, indicating that it is relatively expensive compared to its peers, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$355/sqft to \$35.24/hr, or 10.07. Although the PSF is falling by 0.8% year-over-year, the city remains less affordable. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent without the natural advantage of a low cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is growing at a rate of 0.39% year-over-year, ranking at the 76th percentile. This positive growth rate indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for businesses looking

to hire. The implication is that companies have a growing pool of potential employees to draw from.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is -34.10%, ranking at the 4th percentile, which is significantly low. This sharp decline in building permits signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. Businesses should consider the potential long-term implications of a constrained housing market on their ability to attract and retain employees.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach is 85 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.5%. This indicates a relatively fast-moving market, which can be challenging for relocating workers. The low days on market suggest a competitive housing environment, where homes sell quickly, potentially making it difficult for employees to find and secure housing.

Office Economy

Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach has an office economy percentile rank of 64, indicating a deep professional talent pool. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions that require specialized knowledge workers. However, it may be less ideal for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant.

In conclusion, Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a growing labor force, but it also presents challenges such as a tight labor market and a relatively expensive cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the sharply declining building permits, which could exacerbate affordability issues and hinder the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce, ultimately affecting businesses' ability to attract and retain talent.

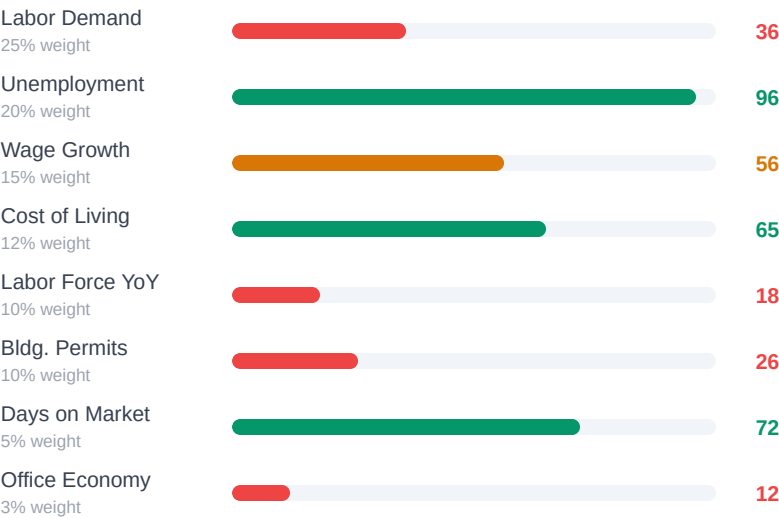
Columbus

Columbus

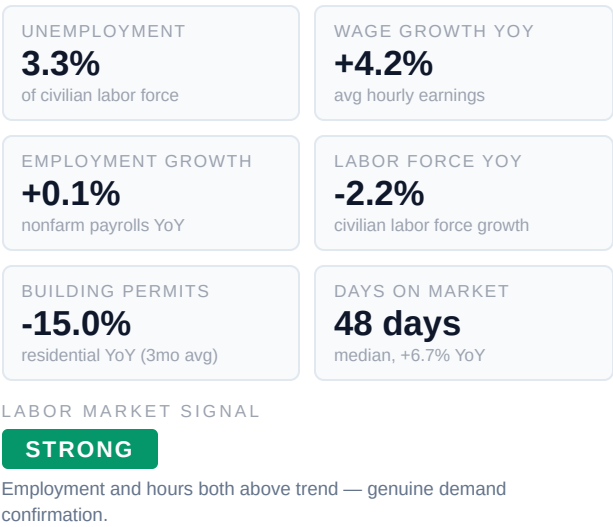
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
52.8th percentile
Rank 19 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Columbus, with an overall grade of B- and a composite score ranking it at the 52.8th percentile among 50 US metros, is characterized by its low unemployment rate of 3.30% and a labor demand composite score of 4.88, which ranks below average at the 36th percentile. The city's economic character is also defined by its stagnant labor force growth and declining building permits. Specifically, the labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges.

Labor Demand

Columbus has an employment growth rate of +0.06% and weekly hours deviation of +0.492% from its own trend, indicating a moderate expansion of labor demand. However, the combination of these metrics suggests that the city is experiencing a genuine demand expansion, albeit at a slow pace. This signals that businesses may face some competition for talent, but the market is not overly tight.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Columbus is 3.30%, ranking at the 96th percentile, which indicates a very tight labor market. This means that businesses may face significant challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is relatively small. As a result, companies may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Columbus is +4.15%, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. At the same time, workers in the city are experiencing a moderate increase in purchasing power, which could support local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

Columbus has a cost of living score that ranks at the 65th percentile, with a PSF of \$205/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$34.84/hr, resulting in a ratio of 5.88. This suggests that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. As a result, businesses may be able to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums to offset high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Columbus is shrinking at a rate of -2.20% year-over-year, indicating a contraction in the supply of available workers. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant challenge for businesses looking to hire, as it may limit their ability to find qualified candidates.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Columbus has declined by -14.98% year-over-year, suggesting that the housing supply is tightening. This decline in building permits may lead to future affordability challenges and limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Columbus is currently 48 days, with a year-over-year increase of +6.7%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the relatively slow pace of sales may also indicate a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

Columbus has a professional and office worker share that ranks at the 12th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. As a result, the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep pool of specialized office or professional talent, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms.

In conclusion, Columbus offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate pace of wage growth, but its tight labor market and declining labor force growth pose significant challenges for hiring and expansion. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's shrinking labor force, which may limit the availability of qualified candidates and hinder business growth.

Atlanta

Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
51.8th percentile
Rank 20 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		12
25% weight		
Unemployment		84
20% weight		
Wage Growth		36
15% weight		
Cost of Living		76
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		86
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		62
10% weight		
Days on Market		36
5% weight		
Office Economy		32
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.4% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH -0.5% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +1.2% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS +15.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 60 days median, 0.0% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL SQUEEZE Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.8th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.40% ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. Specifically, the labor demand is characterized by a -0.46% employment growth rate and a +0.595% weekly hours deviation from its own trend.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Atlanta is -0.46% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.595% from its own 12-month trend, signaling a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine expansion. This combination indicates that while hours are slightly above trend, the overall job market is not adding positions, suggesting a potential survivor squeeze where remaining workers absorb the load of eliminated roles. This metric is in the bottom tier at the 12th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Atlanta is 3.40%, which ranks in the top tier at the 84th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure as a result. For a company trying to hire in this market, it may be necessary to offer competitive wages to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Atlanta is +3.11% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not as quickly as in other metros, and worker purchasing power is increasing, albeit at a slower pace. This could be beneficial for businesses looking to manage labor costs while still offering competitive compensation.

Cost of Living

Atlanta has a cost of living score that ranks above average at the 76th percentile, with a PSF of \$194/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.62, resulting in a ratio of 5.16. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.5% year-over-year contributes to its relatively high affordability score. This means that Atlanta has a talent attraction advantage due to its affordability, allowing businesses to attract workers without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Atlanta is growing at a rate of +1.18% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 86th percentile. This positive growth indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a favorable condition for hiring. As the labor force grows, businesses in Atlanta may find it easier to fill open positions and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Atlanta has increased by +15.21% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 62nd percentile. This rise in permits suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could lead to improved affordability and a more accommodating environment for the workforce in the future. This is a positive sign for businesses considering relocation, as it indicates a potential for a more stable and affordable housing market for their employees.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Atlanta is 60 days, with a year-over-year change of +0.0%, ranking below average at the 36th percentile. This relatively fast market means that homes are selling quickly, which could make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. However, the stable year-over-year change suggests a balanced market that is not overly competitive.

Office Economy

Atlanta's professional and office worker share ranks below average at the 32nd percentile, indicating a less deep talent pool in these sectors compared to other metros. This suggests that Atlanta is better suited for businesses that are not heavily reliant on tech, finance, consulting, or HQ operations, and may be more accommodating to industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and moderate wage growth, along with an expanding labor force and improving housing affordability. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to consider is the low labor demand, which could signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or establish a strong foothold in the market.

San Antonio

San Antonio-New Braunfels

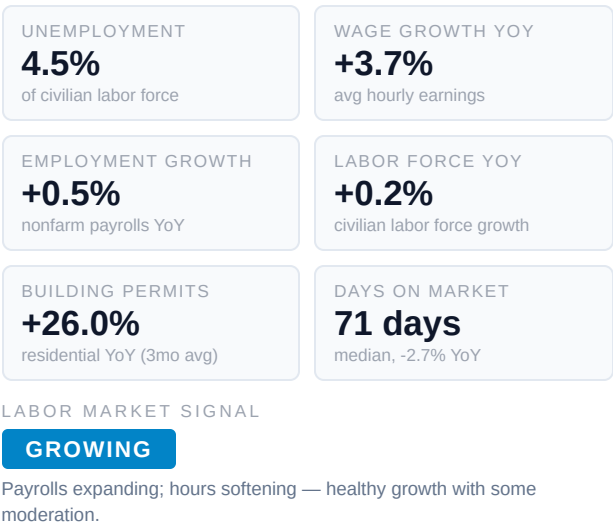
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
51.2th percentile
Rank 21 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 51.2th percentile among 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with a composite score of 4.36, and its highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile. The cost of living is particularly notable, with a price per square foot of \$170 and average hourly earnings of \$33.17, resulting in a ratio of 5.13.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 0.51% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.651% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are not running above trend during a period of job growth. Instead, it may indicate a moderate pace of job additions without significant pressure on labor resources.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 4.50%, which is below average, ranking at the 30th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. However, it is not as competitive as other cities with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 3.73%, which is near the median, ranking at the 50th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising at a steady pace, while worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This balance may appeal to businesses seeking to manage labor costs without sacrificing worker satisfaction.

Cost of Living

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a highly affordable cost of living, ranked at the 92nd percentile, with a price per square foot of \$170 and average hourly earnings of \$33.17. This affordability advantage is driven by a -3.4% year-over-year decrease in price per square foot. As a result, the city offers a significant talent attraction advantage without requiring wage premiums to compensate for high living costs.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Antonio-New Braunfels is growing at a rate of 0.23% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This expansion of the labor force supply indicates a positive trend for hiring capacity, as the pool of potential workers is increasing.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Antonio-New Braunfels has increased by 25.98% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking at the 76th percentile. This significant expansion of housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, reducing the risk of a supply squeeze.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in San Antonio-New Braunfels is 71 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -2.7%. This relatively fast pace of home sales indicates a competitive market, which may pose challenges for relocating workers. However, the decreasing trend in days on market suggests a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

San Antonio-New Braunfels has a deep professional talent pool, ranked at the 76th percentile, with a share of jobs in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but less ideal for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Antonio-New Braunfels metro area offers businesses a unique combination of affordable living costs, moderate wage growth, and an expanding labor force. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the below-average labor demand, which may limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth or expansion.

Nashville

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin

B-

BELOW AVERAGE
51.2th percentile
Rank 22 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		46
Unemployment 20% weight		80
Wage Growth 15% weight		52
Cost of Living 12% weight		49
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		46
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		18
Days on Market 5% weight		26
Office Economy 3% weight		78

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 3.2% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +3.9% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.7% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -1.3% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -17.8% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 62 days median, +5.1% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking at the 51.2th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 3.20% and its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.26, indicating a mix of job growth and stable hours worked. The combination of these metrics suggests a relatively stable labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is +0.65% year-over-year, with weekly hours deviating +0.047% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, as jobs are being added and hours are running above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.26, ranking at the 46th percentile, further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 3.20%, ranking at the 80th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. The tight market implies that employers may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is +3.92%, ranking at the 52nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a manageable pace, while workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power. The moderate wage growth implies a relatively stable labor cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has a cost of living score ranking at the 49th percentile, with a PSF of \$259/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.74/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.25. The city's cost of living is near median, but the -1.1% year-over-year change in PSF suggests a slight improvement in affordability. This means that the city may not require significant wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively manageable.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking at the 46th percentile. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking.

Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to accommodate this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is -17.83%, ranking at the 18th percentile, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply. This tightening of the housing market may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation, posing a risk to future business growth.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin is 62 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.1%, ranking at the 26th percentile. This suggests a relatively slow market, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, the rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin has an office economy score ranking at the 78th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in professional and office sectors. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions, but less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin offers a relatively stable labor market with low unemployment, but also poses challenges such as a shrinking labor force and tightening housing market. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential for decreased affordability and increased competition for workforce accommodation, which may impact future growth and hiring capacity.

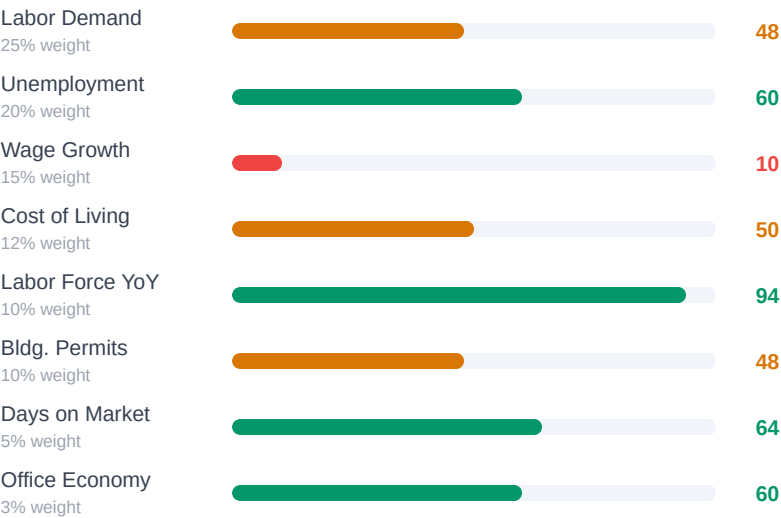
Cleveland

Cleveland

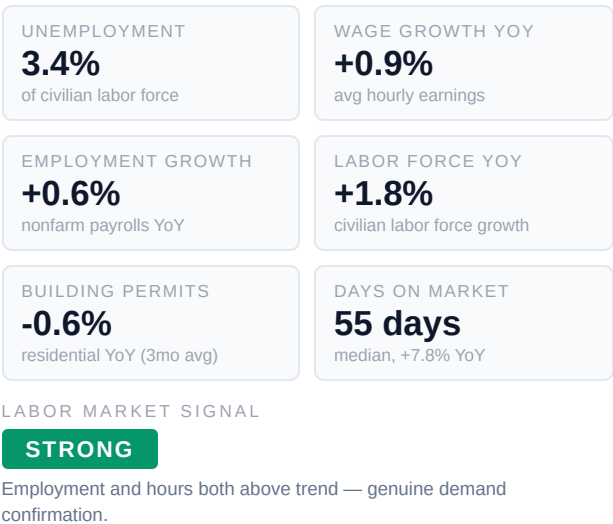
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
50.7th percentile
Rank 23 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Cleveland earns an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 50.7th percentile among 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand and low wage growth, with a labor demand composite score of 5.27 and wage growth of +0.88% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some positive trends but also areas of concern.

Labor Demand

Cleveland's employment growth rate is +0.57% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.170%, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, albeit a modest one, as hours are running above trend during a period of job growth. This suggests that the city is experiencing some level of economic expansion, but not at a rapid pace.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Cleveland is 3.40%, ranking above average at the 60th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Cleveland is +0.88% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies that workers have limited bargaining power and purchasing power. This could impact the overall attractiveness of the city to businesses and workers alike.

Cost of Living

Cleveland's cost of living is near median, with a percentile rank of 50th, and a PSF-to-earnings ratio of \$143/sqft to \$34.26/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.17. The city's PSF is increasing by +13.5% year-over-year, which may impact affordability. This means that the city is neither particularly affordable nor expensive relative to its peers, and businesses may not need to offer significant wage premiums to attract talent.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Cleveland is growing at a rate of +1.80% year-over-year, ranking in the top tier at the 94th percentile, indicating an expanding workforce supply. This positive trend suggests that the city has a growing pool of potential workers, making it easier for businesses to hire and expand their operations.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Cleveland is decreasing by -0.61% year-over-year, ranking near median at the 48th percentile, indicating a tightening housing supply. This trend signals that the city's housing market may become less affordable in the future, potentially impacting workforce accommodation and attraction.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Cleveland is 55 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.8%, ranking above average at the 64th percentile. This suggests that the housing market is becoming less competitive, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. However, this trend may also indicate a slowing demand for housing.

Office Economy

Cleveland's professional and office worker share is 2.86, ranking above average at the 60th percentile, indicating a deep talent pool suited for tech, finance, consulting, and HQ decisions. This makes the city an attractive location for businesses in these sectors, but less suitable for industries with limited specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Cleveland offers a mixed economic environment with some positive trends, such as labor force growth and a deep professional talent pool. However, the city's low wage growth and tightening housing supply are significant concerns that businesses should factor into their location decisions, as they may impact labor costs, talent attraction, and overall competitiveness.

Washington DC

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria

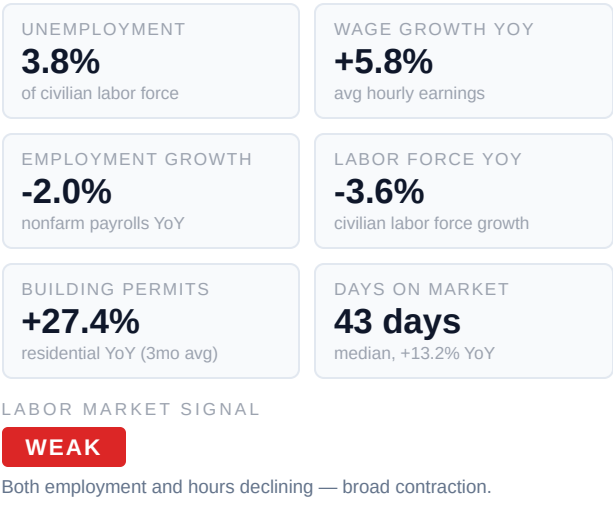
B-

BELOW AVERAGE
50.4th percentile
Rank 24 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area has an overall grade of B- with a composite score ranking it at the 50.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, at 5.85% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both opportunities and challenges for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is -1.96% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by -0.606%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours. This suggests that businesses may face a relatively easy time hiring, but may also need to consider the potential for a shrinking workforce.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 3.80%, which ranks at the 78th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in finding and hiring qualified workers, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent. The tight labor market also suggests that workers may have more bargaining power, which could drive up labor costs.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 5.85%, which is in the top tier of US metros. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers may be rising quickly, but it also indicates that workers have strong purchasing power. This could be beneficial for businesses that rely on a highly skilled and highly paid workforce.

Cost of Living

Washington-Arlington-Alexandria has a cost of living score that ranks at the 67th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$301/sqft to \$45.93/hr, or 6.55. The fact that the PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable relative to wages. This could be a talent attraction advantage for businesses, as workers may be able to afford a higher quality of life without requiring wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is shrinking at a rate of -3.61% year-over-year. This contraction in labor force supply suggests that businesses may face structural headwinds in hiring and expanding their workforce. The shrinking labor pool could limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is increasing by 27.36% year-over-year. This expansion in housing supply suggests that the city is becoming more accommodating to a growing workforce, and that future affordability may improve. The increase in building permits is a positive signal for businesses that rely on a growing and diverse workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 13.2%. This suggests that the housing market is slowing down, which could make it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. The slower market could be beneficial for businesses that need to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Washington-Arlington-Alexandria ranks at the 32nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city may be less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, the city may still be attractive to businesses that require a more general workforce.

The Washington-Arlington-Alexandria metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and a relatively tight labor market, which could be beneficial for companies that require a highly skilled workforce. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the shrinking labor force, which could limit the city's ability to support rapid business growth and expansion.

San Francisco

San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont

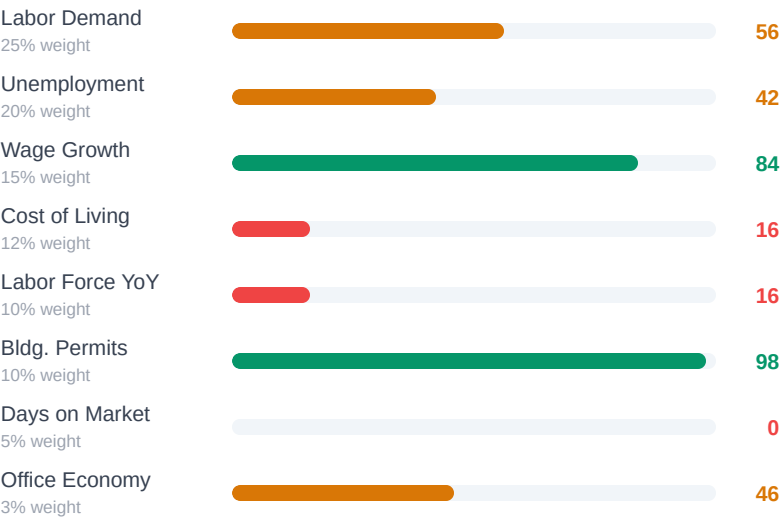
C+

FAIR

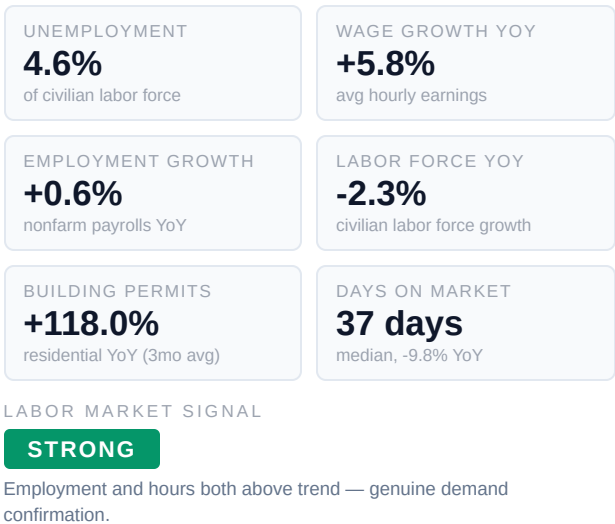
49.7th percentile

Rank 25 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 49.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.78%, and its extremely competitive housing market, with a median days on market of 37 days and a year-over-year decrease of 9.8%. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to attract and retain talent.

Labor Demand

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has an employment growth rate of 0.56% and a weekly hours deviation of 0.469% above its own trend, indicating a near median labor demand composite score of 5.55. This combination signals a genuine demand expansion, with jobs being added and hours running above trend. However, the relatively modest employment growth rate suggests that this demand expansion is not overly robust.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 4.60%, ranking it near the median at the 42nd percentile. This rate indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but not an abundance of available workers. For a business trying to hire in this market, this means that hiring may be moderately challenging, with some upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 5.78%, ranking it in the top tier at the 84th percentile. This fast wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising rapidly, while worker purchasing power is increasing. This may be beneficial for workers but poses a challenge for businesses looking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a cost of living ratio of \$627/sqft to \$50.39/hr, with a year-over-year decrease of 4.3% in PSF, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile in terms of affordability. This means that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers, which may make it difficult to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The falling PSF relative to wages is a positive sign, but the overall cost of living remains a significant challenge.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is contracting at a rate of -2.31% year-over-year, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 16th percentile. This decline in labor force supply suggests that hiring capacity may be constrained, making it even more challenging for businesses to attract and retain talent.

Building Permits

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has seen a year-over-year increase of 118.02% in residential building permits, ranking it in the top tier at the 98th percentile. This rapid expansion of housing supply is a positive sign for future affordability and workforce accommodation, suggesting that the city may become more attractive to workers and businesses in the long term.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in the San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area is 37 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 9.8%. This extremely competitive market means that workers relocating to the city may face significant challenges in finding and securing housing, making the city less accessible to newcomers.

Office Economy

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area has a professional and office worker share of 2.36, ranking it near the median at the 46th percentile. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, and consulting, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong wage growth and a rapidly expanding housing supply, but it also poses significant challenges in terms of labor costs, talent attraction, and housing affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the extremely competitive housing market, which may make it difficult to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums or other incentives.

Houston

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands

C+

FAIR

48.5th percentile

Rank 26 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		74
25% weight		
Unemployment		18
20% weight		
Wage Growth		12
15% weight		
Cost of Living		69
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		80
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		44
10% weight		
Days on Market		28
5% weight		
Office Economy		84
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 5.0% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +1.2% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +1.3% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY +0.6% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -2.2% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 55 days median, -1.8% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 48.5th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its above-average labor demand, with a composite score at the 74th percentile, and its relatively low unemployment rate of 5.00%, which ranks at the 18th percentile. The labor demand and unemployment metrics suggest a city with genuine job growth but also some challenges in finding the right talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.30% year-over-year, combined with a +0.091% deviation in weekly hours from its own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing real job growth, with hours worked above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are in demand. The labor demand composite score of 6.21 further supports this interpretation, ranking at the 74th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is 5.00%, ranking at the 18th percentile, which indicates a relatively high level of unemployment compared to other cities. This suggests that the job market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire, but it also implies weaker local consumer demand. For a business trying to hire in this city, the relatively high unemployment rate could be an advantage in terms of finding available talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is +1.21%, ranking at the 12th percentile, which indicates stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers, but it also means that workers have weak bargaining power and limited purchasing power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but they may also struggle to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a cost of living score ranking at the 69th percentile, with a PSF of \$169/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$36.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.58. The fact that PSF is falling by -1.7% year-over-year suggests that the city is becoming more affordable. This makes it an attractive location for talent, as businesses can offer competitive wages without needing significant premiums to account for the cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is growing at a rate of +0.64% year-over-year, ranking at the 80th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire. The growing labor force suggests that the city has a strong pipeline of potential employees, making it easier for companies to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has decreased by -2.18% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 44th percentile. This decline in building permits suggests that the housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. As a result, businesses may need to consider the potential impact of a tightening housing market on their ability to attract and retain talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands is currently 55 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -1.8%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking at the 28th percentile, suggests a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers. However, the decreasing days on market could also indicate a healthy and dynamic housing market, which could be attractive to some businesses and employees.

Office Economy

Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy score ranking at the 84th percentile. This suggests that the city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, which require a high concentration of specialized knowledge workers. However, the city may be less suited for industries that are more industrial or logistics-dominant, which may require a different type of workforce.

The Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands metro area offers businesses a unique combination of above-average labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for talent. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the potential impact of a tightening housing market on future affordability and workforce accommodation, which could limit the city's ability to support long-term business growth and expansion.

Birmingham

Birmingham

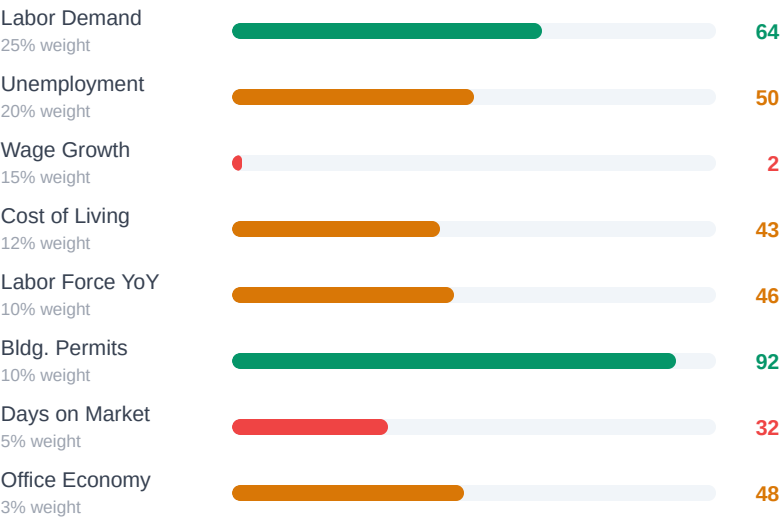
C+

FAIR

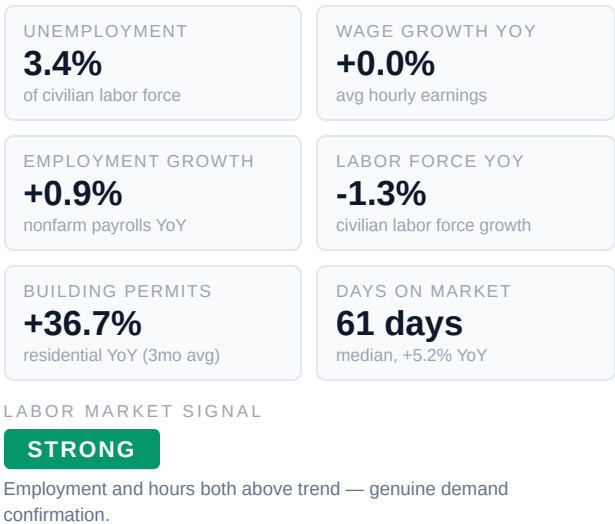
48.3th percentile

Rank 27 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Birmingham, with an overall grade of C+ and a composite score ranking it 48.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.94, driven by a +0.92% employment growth rate and +0.349% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. Additionally, its building permits growth of +36.73% year-over-year highlights a strong developer confidence in the market.

Labor Demand

Birmingham's employment growth rate of +0.92% and weekly hours deviation of +0.349% from its own trend indicate a genuine demand expansion, suggesting that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours than usual. This combination signals a healthy labor market where businesses can find workers with increasing hours, indicating a strong demand for labor. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 further reinforces this, ranking above average at the 64th percentile.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate of 3.40% places it near the median, ranking at the 50th percentile. This rate suggests that the labor market has some slack, making it relatively easier for businesses to hire compared to tighter markets. However, this also implies that local consumer demand might not be as strong as in areas with lower unemployment rates.

Wage Growth

With a year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.03%, Birmingham's wage growth is stagnant, ranking at the bottom tier of the 2nd percentile. This slow wage growth environment means that labor costs for employers are not increasing rapidly, but it also signifies weak bargaining power for workers and potentially limited purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Birmingham's cost of living, with a PSF of \$157/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$32.71/hr, resulting in a ratio of 4.80, ranks near the median at the 43rd percentile. The city's PSF is decreasing by -1.3% year-over-year, which is a key driver of its affordability. This affordability makes the city more attractive for talent without necessitating significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Birmingham is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 46th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of potential workers is shrinking.

Building Permits

The city's residential building permits have increased by +36.73% year-over-year, placing it in the top tier at the 92nd percentile. This significant growth in building permits signals an expansion in future housing supply, which should improve affordability and accommodate a growing workforce.

Days on Market

Homes in Birmingham currently sit on the market for a median of 61 days, with a year-over-year increase of +5.2%. This increase in days on market, ranking below average at the 32nd percentile, suggests a slightly slower market, which could be more accessible for relocating workers.

Office Economy

Birmingham's professional and office worker share, with a composite score of 2.46, ranks near the median at the 48th percentile. This indicates a moderately deep talent pool suited for businesses requiring professional and office skills, though it may not be as competitive as cities with higher rankings in this metric.

In conclusion, Birmingham offers a mix of above-average labor demand and top-tier building permit growth, making it an attractive location for businesses looking to expand. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the stagnant wage growth, which, while keeping labor costs low, may also limit worker purchasing power and attract fewer skilled workers due to the lack of wage growth opportunities.

Oklahoma City

Oklahoma City

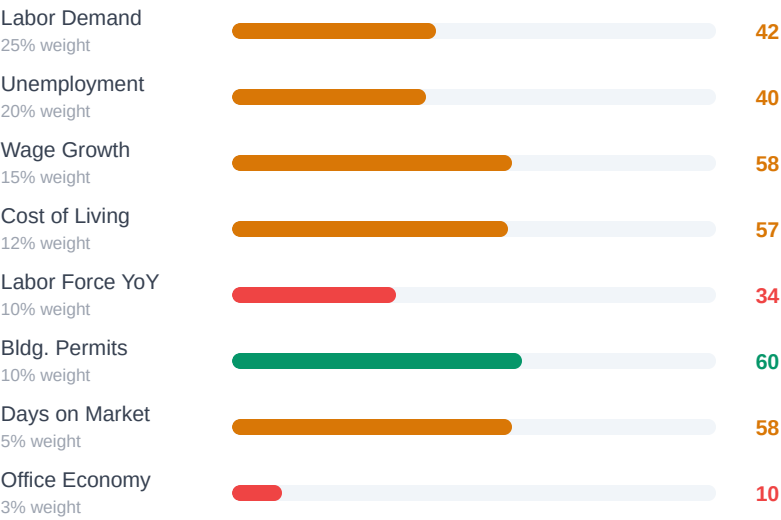
C+

FAIR

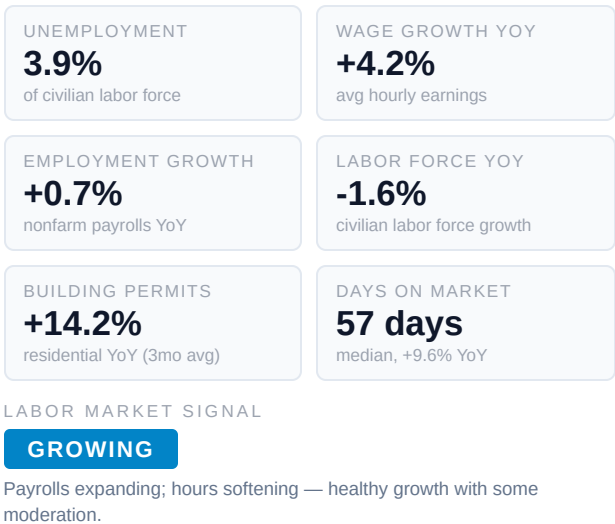
46.7th percentile

Rank 28 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Oklahoma City has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 46.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its near-median labor demand composite score of 5.17 and its below-average labor force growth rate of -1.65% YoY. These metrics suggest a mixed economic environment, with some signs of stability but also challenges in expanding the workforce.

Labor Demand

Oklahoma City's employment growth rate is +0.74% YoY, while weekly hours are -0.163% below trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked slightly below the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating some slack in labor demand. The labor demand composite score of 5.17 is near the median, suggesting a relatively stable but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Oklahoma City is 3.90%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This rate indicates a relatively balanced labor market, neither extremely tight nor overly slack. For a business trying to hire in this city, the moderate unemployment rate suggests that finding talent may not be excessively difficult, but wage pressure is not entirely absent either.

Wage Growth

Wage growth in Oklahoma City is +4.20% YoY, which is near the median at the 58th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not at an alarming pace. At the same time, workers are experiencing an increase in purchasing power, which can contribute to local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$171/sqft to \$34.33/hr, Oklahoma City ranks near the median at the 57th percentile in terms of affordability. This means the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, which can be a talent attraction advantage without necessitating significant wage premiums. The slight increase in PSF (+0.6% YoY) does not significantly erode this affordability.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Oklahoma City is shrinking at a rate of -1.65% YoY, indicating a contracting labor pool. This negative growth rate poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and retaining talent in this environment.

Building Permits

Residential building permits in Oklahoma City are increasing by +14.19% YoY, signaling an expansion in future housing supply. This growth in permits suggests that developer confidence is strong, and the city's affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve over time.

Days on Market

Homes in Oklahoma City are currently sitting on the market for 57 days, with a +9.6% YoY increase in days on market. This indicates a slightly slower market, which can be more accessible for relocating workers. However, the relatively fast pace of sales still suggests a competitive environment for homebuyers.

Office Economy

Oklahoma City's professional and office worker share ranks in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms, but may be more appropriate for industries with different workforce needs.

In conclusion, Oklahoma City offers a relatively stable labor market and affordable cost of living, which can be attractive for certain types of businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's shrinking labor force, which poses significant challenges for hiring and workforce expansion. This factor should be carefully weighed in any location decision.

Boston

Boston-Cambridge-Newton

C+

FAIR

45.0th percentile

Rank 29 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand		26
25% weight		
Unemployment		26
20% weight		
Wage Growth		32
15% weight		
Cost of Living		22
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		98
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		94
10% weight		
Days on Market		98
5% weight		
Office Economy		56
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 3.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +2.9%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY -0.1%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth +2.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +72.3%	DAYS ON MARKET median, +19.4% YoY 43 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL WEAK Both employment and hours declining — broad contraction.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking at the 45.0th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its strong labor force growth of 2.87% YoY and its high building permits growth of 72.27% YoY, indicating a expanding workforce and housing supply. The labor demand composite score of 4.13, however, suggests a below-average labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate is -0.12% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating -0.351% from the city's own 12-month baseline, signaling a contraction in labor demand. This combination indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, with hours below trend during a period of job losses, suggesting a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This metric ranks at the 26th percentile, below average.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate is 3.90%, ranking at the 26th percentile, indicating a below-average labor market with some slack. This means that while it may not be extremely difficult to hire, there is still some competition for talent, and businesses may face moderate wage pressure. The market is not extremely tight, but it is not loose either, presenting a moderate challenge for hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate is +2.93%, ranking at the 32nd percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely quickly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. This moderate wage growth presents a manageable cost environment for businesses.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Boston-Cambridge-Newton is below average, with a percentile rank of 22, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The PSF to earnings ratio is \$459/sqft vs \$45.83/hr, resulting in a ratio of 10.02, and PSF is falling -3.0% YoY. This means that the city may require wage premiums to attract talent, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of 2.87% YoY, ranking at the 98th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding workforce supply. This strong growth suggests that hiring capacity is increasing, and businesses may find it easier to attract talent in the future. The expanding labor force presents a significant advantage for businesses looking to hire.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +72.27%, ranking at the 94th percentile, indicating a rapidly expanding housing supply. This growth suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation are likely to improve, as more housing options become available. The increasing housing supply presents a positive signal for businesses considering relocation.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of 19.4%, ranking at the 98th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold, presenting a more accessible and less competitive environment for workers relocating to the city. The rising days on market suggests a healthy normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

The share of jobs in professional and office sectors is 2.70, ranking at the 56th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of professional talent pool. This city is well-suited for businesses that require a moderate level of specialized knowledge workers, such as tech, finance, or consulting, but may not be the best fit for industries that require a very deep talent pool.

The Boston-Cambridge-Newton metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a rapidly expanding labor force and housing supply, presenting opportunities for growth and talent attraction. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the relatively high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent, potentially increasing labor costs for businesses.

Portland

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro

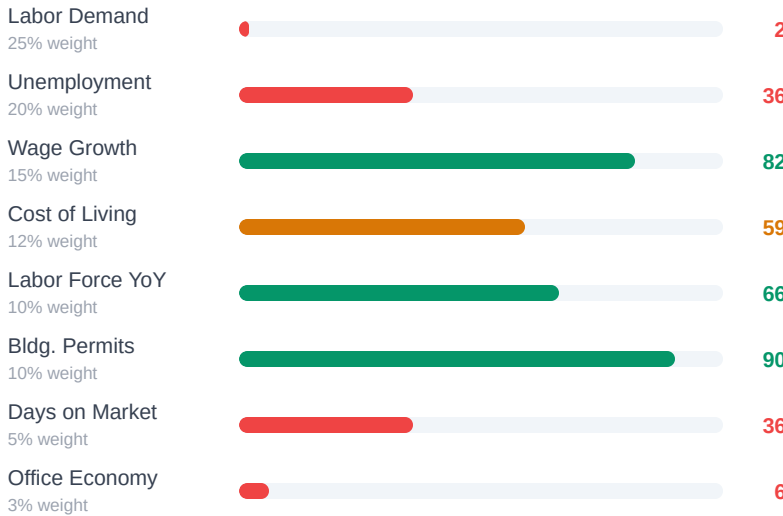
C+

FAIR

44.7th percentile

Rank 30 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.9%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+5.7%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.5%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

+0.1%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+32.3%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

66 days
median, 0.0% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

6 Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier, and its high wage growth, with a year-over-year increase of 5.68%. The combination of these metrics suggests a complex economic environment, with both challenges and opportunities for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is -1.52% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.368%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than genuine demand expansion or survivor squeeze. The low labor demand composite score of 1.80, ranking in the bottom tier, further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 4.90%, which is below average, ranking in the 36th percentile. This indicates a relatively tight labor market, with some slack but not a significant amount. For a business trying to hire in this city, this means that finding the right talent may be challenging, and wage pressure may be present.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 5.68%, which is a relatively fast pace, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This implies that labor costs for employers are rising, but worker purchasing power is also increasing. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering this location.

Cost of Living

Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro has a cost of living score ranking in the 59th percentile, with a PSF of \$303/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$42.52/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.13. This suggests that the city is near the median in terms of affordability. The fact that PSF is falling by 2.3% year-over-year is a positive sign for affordability. This means that businesses may be able to attract talent without needing to offer significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is growing at a rate of 0.05% year-over-year, which is above average, ranking in the 66th percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is slowly expanding, which is a positive sign for hiring capacity. However, the growth rate is relatively slow, so businesses should not expect a large influx of new talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is increasing by 32.26% year-over-year, which is a significant expansion, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 66 days, with no year-over-year change. This indicates a relatively stable housing market, neither extremely competitive nor extremely accessible. For a worker relocating to this city, this means that finding a home may take some time, but it is not an extremely challenging market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro is 0.72, ranking in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile. This suggests that the city has a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors, making it less suited for businesses that rely heavily on professional and office workers, such as tech or finance companies.

The Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and expanding housing supply, but it also presents challenges, such as low labor demand and a relatively tight labor market. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the potential for labor costs to rise due to the high wage growth, which could impact business profitability.

Providence

Providence-Warwick

C+

FAIR

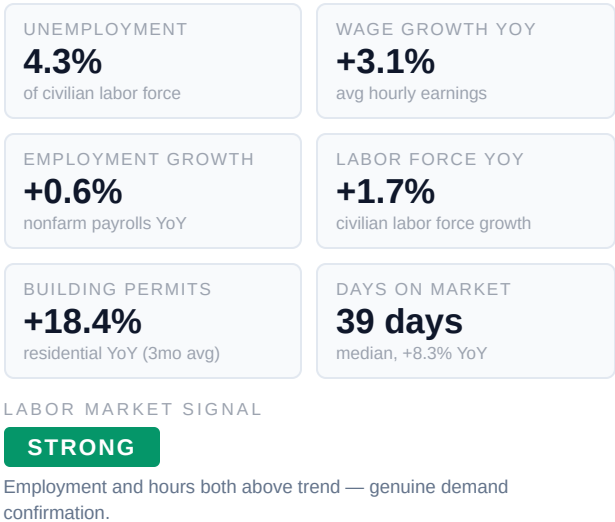
44.7th percentile

Rank 31 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Providence-Warwick metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high labor force growth rate of +1.69% YoY and its low unemployment rate of 4.30%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests a city with a strong workforce supply but also intense competition for talent.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +0.60% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating +0.326% from the city's own 12-month baseline, resulting in a labor demand composite score of 5.47, which ranks near the median at 54th percentile. This combination signals genuine demand expansion, as both jobs and hours are increasing. However, the moderate growth rate indicates a stable rather than booming labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Providence-Warwick is 4.30%, ranking in the bottom tier at 18th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with limited slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city will face significant competition for talent and may need to offer higher wages to attract workers. The tight labor market also suggests that workers have more bargaining power.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Providence-Warwick is +3.09%, which ranks below average at 34th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so. Workers in this city will see some improvement in their purchasing power, but it may not be enough to keep pace with cost of living increases.

Cost of Living

Providence-Warwick has a cost of living score that ranks in the bottom tier at 2nd percentile, with a PSF to earnings ratio of \$360/sqft vs \$36.41/hr, resulting in a ratio of 9.89. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising +8.4% YoY relative to wages makes it even less affordable. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract talent to this city.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Providence-Warwick is growing at a rate of +1.69% YoY, which ranks in the top tier at 92nd percentile. This indicates that the workforce supply is expanding rapidly, which is a positive sign for businesses looking to hire in this city. The growing labor force suggests that there will be a larger pool of potential workers to draw from.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Providence-Warwick is increasing by +18.42% YoY, which ranks above average at 68th percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which should improve affordability and accommodation options for workers in the future. The increase in building permits is a positive sign for businesses concerned about the ability of their workers to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Providence-Warwick is currently 39 days, with a year-over-year increase of +8.3%, ranking in the top tier at 86th percentile. This indicates a slower market, which may make it easier for relocating workers to find homes. However, the relatively fast days on market compared to other cities suggests that the market is still competitive.

Office Economy

Providence-Warwick has an office economy score that ranks above average at 64th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.92 out of 5. This indicates a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, the city may be less suited for businesses in industrial or logistics-dominant sectors.

The Providence-Warwick metro area offers businesses a unique combination of a tight labor market and rapid labor force growth, making it an attractive location for companies looking to hire talented workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses in this city is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Phoenix

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler

C+

FAIR

44.6th percentile

Rank 32 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)

Labor Demand 25% weight		76
Unemployment 20% weight		8
Wage Growth 15% weight		40
Cost of Living 12% weight		55
Labor Force YoY 10% weight		8
Bldg. Permits 10% weight		56
Days on Market 5% weight		52
Office Economy 3% weight		80

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT of civilian labor force 4.9%	WAGE GROWTH YOY avg hourly earnings +3.3%
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH nonfarm payrolls YoY +0.9%	LABOR FORCE YOY civilian labor force growth -2.9%
BUILDING PERMITS residential YoY (3mo avg) +11.0%	DAYS ON MARKET median, -4.6% YoY 62 days
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area has an overall grade of C+ with a composite score ranking it 44.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 76th percentile, and its labor force growth, which is in the bottom tier at 8th percentile with a -2.93% year-over-year change. The combination of these metrics signals a city with strong job growth but a shrinking labor pool.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +0.91% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating +0.771% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing a period of job growth where hours are running above trend, suggesting that businesses are hiring and workers are absorbing more hours. The labor demand composite score of 6.34 further supports this interpretation.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 4.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with little slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in this city may face challenges in finding available workers, leading to potential wage pressure. With such a low unemployment rate, companies may need to offer competitive salaries to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not excessively so, and worker purchasing power is increasing at a steady pace. While this is not the fastest wage growth, it still indicates a relatively healthy labor market.

Cost of Living

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a cost of living percentile rank of 55th, with a PSF of \$264/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$38.11/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.93. This near-median ranking indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers, especially since the PSF is falling -1.9% year-over-year. This affordability can be a significant talent attraction advantage for businesses, as they may not need to offer wage premiums to compensate for a high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is shrinking at a rate of -2.93% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile. This contraction in labor supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is decreasing.

Businesses may need to consider strategies to attract workers from other areas or invest in training and development programs to build the skills they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has increased by +10.99% year-over-year, ranking near the median at the 56th percentile. This expansion in housing supply signals that developer confidence is rising, and future housing affordability may improve. As a result, the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce is likely to strengthen, making it more attractive to businesses and workers alike.

Days on Market

The current median days on market for homes in Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler is 62 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.6%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers. However, the slight decrease in days on market could suggest a normalization of the market, making it slightly more accessible for newcomers.

Office Economy

Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler has a deep professional talent pool, ranking in the top tier at the 80th percentile for its share of office and professional workers. This makes the city well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors that rely on specialized knowledge-economy talent. Conversely, it may be less ideal for industries with more industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler metro area offers businesses a unique combination of strong labor demand and a relatively affordable cost of living, making it an attractive location for companies looking to expand or relocate. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers to factor in is the shrinking labor force, which could pose significant challenges for hiring and talent acquisition in the long term.

San Jose

San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara

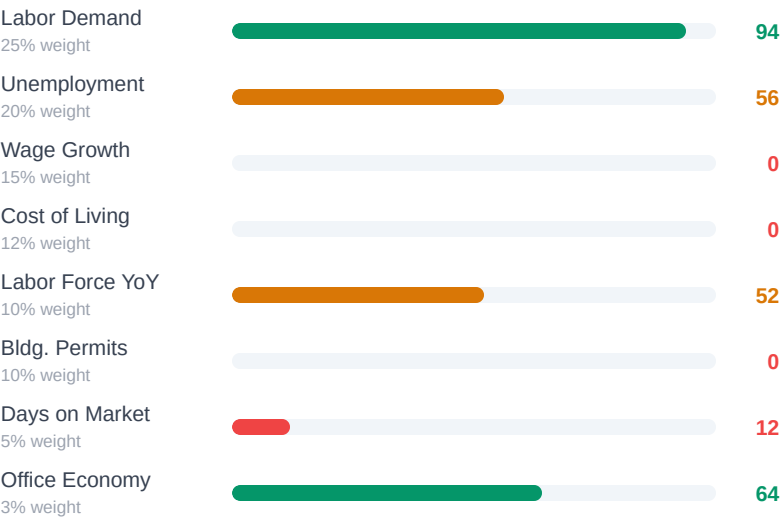
C

VERY POOR

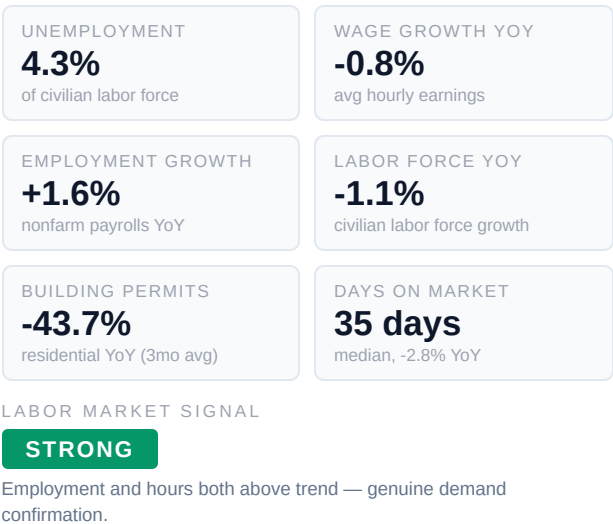
42.4th percentile

Rank 33 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 42.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its strong labor demand and deep office economy. The city's labor demand composite score of 7.81, which combines a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, signals genuine demand expansion. The unemployment rate and cost of living metrics, however, paint a more nuanced picture, with a 4.30% unemployment rate and a cost of living ratio of 15.31, driven by a \$827/sqft housing price and \$54.03/hr average wage.

Labor Demand

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a strong labor demand, with a 1.59% employment growth rate and a 1.289% weekly hours deviation from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is adding jobs and workers are putting in more hours, a positive sign for businesses looking to expand. The labor demand composite score of 7.81 is in the top tier, ranking 94th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 4.30%, ranking 56th percentile, indicating a near-median level of slack in the labor market. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is still relatively competitive, and businesses may face some challenges in hiring. However, the unemployment rate is not so high that it would indicate a large pool of available workers.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is -0.78%, ranking 0th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This means that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing. The stagnant wage growth may make it easier for businesses to control labor costs, but it may also limit the attractiveness of the city to workers.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is relatively expensive, with a ratio of 15.31, driven by a \$827/sqft housing price and \$54.03/hr average wage, ranking 0th percentile. This means that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, which may make it harder to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The high cost of living may be a significant constraint for businesses looking to locate in the area.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is contracting, with a -1.08% year-over-year growth rate, ranking 52nd percentile. This means that the supply of workers is shrinking, which may make it harder for businesses to find the talent they need. The contracting labor

force may be a structural headwind for hiring in the area.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is falling sharply, with a -43.67% year-over-year change, ranking 0th percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability and workforce accommodation challenges. The decline in building permits may signal a supply squeeze ahead, making it harder for workers to find housing.

Days on Market

The median days on market in San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara is 35 days, with a -2.8% year-over-year change, ranking 12th percentile. This means that homes are selling relatively quickly, making it a competitive market for workers relocating to the area. However, the fast-paced market may also indicate a strong demand for housing, which could drive up prices.

Office Economy

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area has a deep professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 64th. This makes it well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, and consulting sectors, but less suited for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses. The city's strong office economy is a significant advantage for businesses looking to tap into a knowledgeable and skilled workforce.

The San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara metro area offers a strong labor demand and a deep office economy, making it an attractive location for businesses in the tech and finance sectors. However, the high cost of living, stagnant wage growth, and tightening housing supply are significant constraints that businesses should factor into their decision-making. The single biggest risk for businesses locating in the area is the high cost of living, which may require wage premiums to attract and retain talent.

Virginia Beach

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk

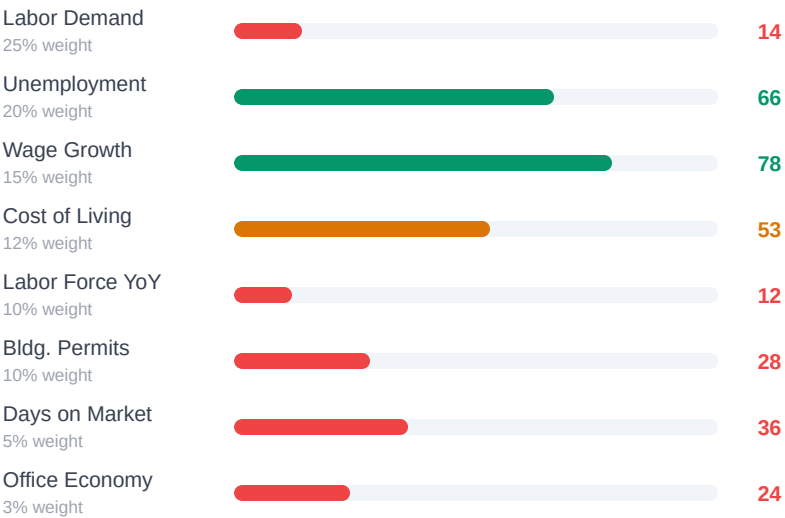
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VERY POOR

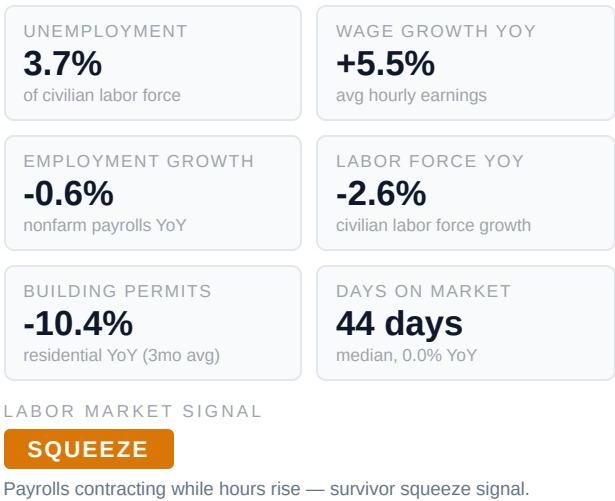
41.3th percentile

Rank 34 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 41.3th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and labor force growth metrics, which both rank in the bottom tier at 14th and 12th percentiles, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 3.36 and labor force growth rate of -2.61% YoY are key indicators of this city's current economic character. These numbers suggest a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -0.55% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.174%, indicating a contraction in labor demand rather than genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 3.36 reinforces this interpretation, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 3.70%, which corresponds to an above-average percentile rank of 66th. This suggests a relatively tight labor market with some slack, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication is that businesses may face some competition for talent, but it's not an extremely tight market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is +5.51%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This indicates fast wage growth, which implies rising labor costs for employers but strong purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for increasing labor costs when considering relocation or expansion.

Cost of Living

Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk has a cost of living percentile rank of 53rd, with a PSF of \$223/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.71, resulting in a ratio of 6.24. This suggests a near-median affordability level, neither extremely high nor low. The city's affordability is not a significant advantage or disadvantage for talent attraction, as the cost of living is relatively average compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is contracting at a rate of -2.61% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses should be cautious when considering expansion or relocation, as the shrinking labor force may limit their ability to find and hire talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is -10.45%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more challenging for workers to relocate to the area.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is 44 days, with a YoY change of +0.0%. This suggests a relatively stable market, neither extremely competitive nor accessible. However, the below-average percentile rank of 36th implies a slightly slower market, which could be beneficial for workers relocating to the area.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk is below average, ranking at the 24th percentile. This indicates a relatively shallow talent pool for businesses requiring specialized knowledge-economy workers, making the city less suited for tech, finance, or consulting businesses. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk metro area offers businesses a relatively tight labor market with fast wage growth, but it also presents significant challenges, including a shrinking labor force and tightening housing supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the limited availability of skilled workers and the potential for decreased affordability, which could hinder a business's ability to attract and retain talent.

New York

New York Newark-Jersey City

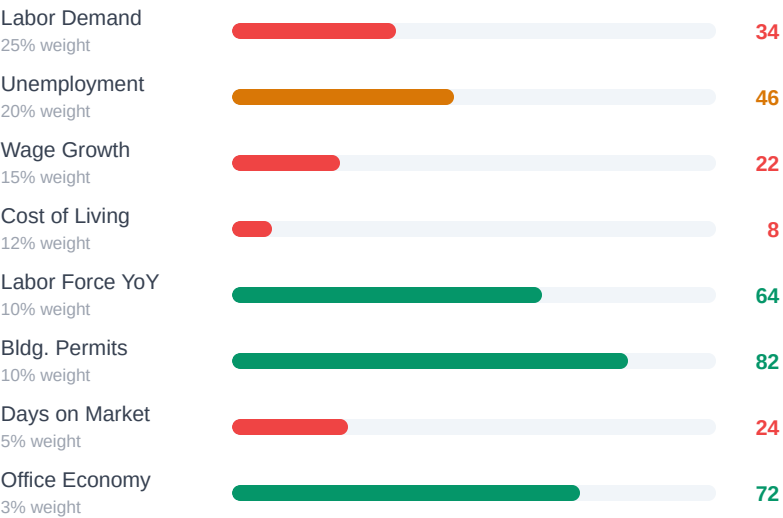
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VERY POOR

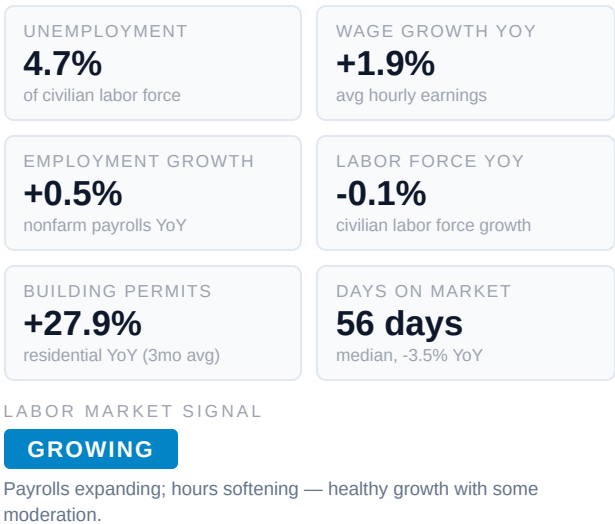
39.9th percentile

Rank 35 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.9th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.80. This city's economic character is most defined by its below-average labor demand, with employment growth of +0.50% and weekly hours deviation of -0.202%, as well as its high cost of living, with a PSF to wages ratio of 12.08. The combination of these metrics suggests a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.50% and weekly hours deviation of -0.202% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers, but it also implies that there may be some slack in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 4.80, ranking in the 34th percentile, further reinforces this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.70% indicates a near-median level of slack in the labor market, ranking in the 46th percentile. This means that while the market is not extremely tight, it is also not overly loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire skilled workers. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in this city is that they may need to offer competitive wages and benefits to attract top talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.91% is below average, ranking in the 22nd percentile. This suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace than in other cities. The implication for worker purchasing power is that it may not be increasing as quickly as in other areas, which could impact local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$494/sqft and a ratio to wages of 12.08, is relatively expensive, ranking in the 8th percentile. This means that the city is less affordable than many of its peers, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The fact that PSF is falling by -0.8% YoY is a positive sign, but the overall affordability score remains low.

Labor Force Growth

The year-over-year growth rate of the civilian labor force is -0.15%, indicating a contracting labor pool. This suggests that the supply of workers is shrinking, which could create structural headwinds for hiring and business expansion. The implication for hiring capacity is that businesses may need to look outside the local labor market to find skilled workers.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +27.93%, indicating an expansion in housing supply. This suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to increase, which could improve affordability and workforce accommodation. The top-tier ranking of 82nd percentile further reinforces this positive outlook.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 56 days, with a year-over-year direction of -3.5%. This suggests that the housing market is relatively fast-paced, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The below-average ranking of 24th percentile indicates that the market is more competitive than accessible for workers looking to relocate.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.96, ranking in the 72nd percentile, indicating a deep talent pool in these sectors. This city is well-suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors, but may be less suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The New York Newark-Jersey City metro area offers businesses a highly skilled and educated workforce, particularly in professional and office sectors. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the high cost of living, which could make it challenging to attract and retain talent without offering significant wage premiums.

Minneapolis

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington

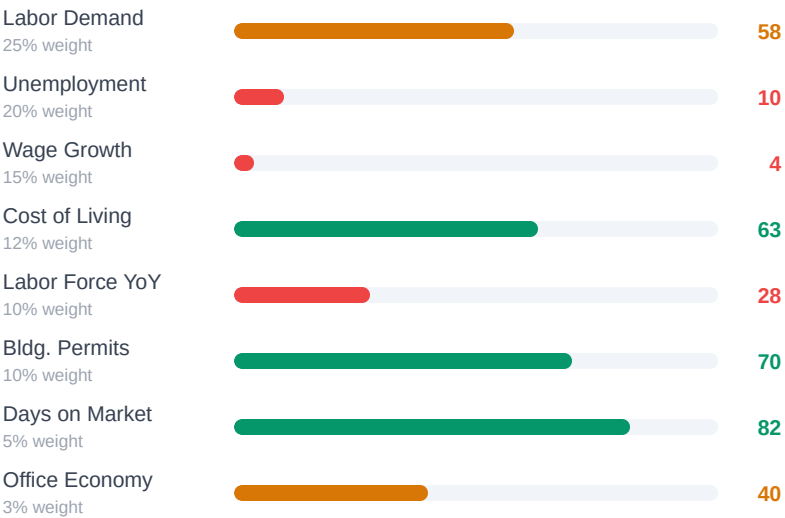
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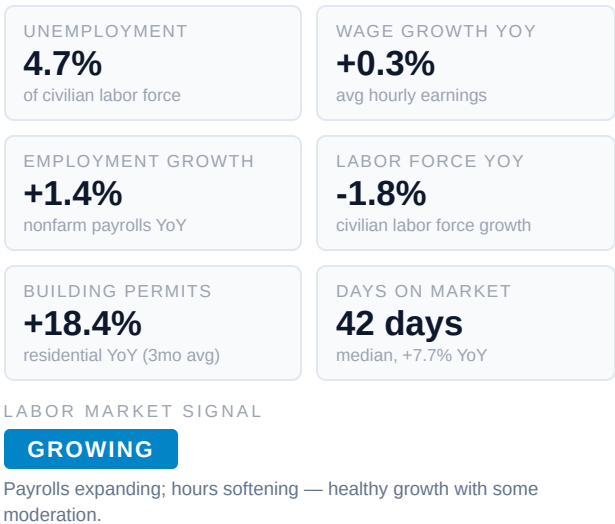
39.8th percentile

Rank 36 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 39.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.57. This city's economic character is most defined by its low unemployment rate of 4.70% and stagnant wage growth of +0.27% year-over-year. The combination of these metrics suggests a tight labor market with limited room for wage growth.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +1.39% year-over-year, while weekly hours are -0.671% below trend. This combination signals a moderate expansion in job numbers, but with hours worked below the 12-month baseline, indicating some degree of survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. The labor demand composite score of 5.57 is near the median, suggesting a balanced but not particularly strong labor market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 4.70%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates a tight labor market with limited slack, making it harder for businesses to hire new employees. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is +0.27%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile. This stagnant wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also implies weak bargaining power for workers and limited growth in worker purchasing power. This may impact the overall attractiveness of the city for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Cost of Living

Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington has a cost of living score of 63rd percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$206/sqft to \$40.75/hr, indicating that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -2.4% year-over-year relative to wages further supports this affordability. This makes the city more attractive for talent attraction without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is contracting at a rate of -1.77% year-over-year, ranking below average at the 28th percentile. This decline in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to compensate for this trend.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is increasing by +18.45% year-over-year, ranking above average at the 70th percentile. This expansion in housing supply suggests that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing options become available to support a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.7%, ranking in the top tier at the 82nd percentile. This indicates a slower market where homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for relocating workers to find housing. However, this trend may also signal a normalization of the market rather than a demand erosion.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington is ranked near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating a moderate depth of talent pool in these sectors. This city is best suited for businesses that can thrive in a mixed economy with a balance of industrial, logistics, and office sectors, but may not be the top choice for businesses requiring a deep pool of specialized tech or finance talent.

The Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington metro area offers a relatively affordable cost of living and a moderate labor market, but the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the tight labor market with limited room for wage growth, posing challenges for hiring and talent retention. Despite this, the city's expanding housing supply and slowing housing market may provide opportunities for businesses looking to relocate or expand in a more accessible and affordable environment.

Sacramento

Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom

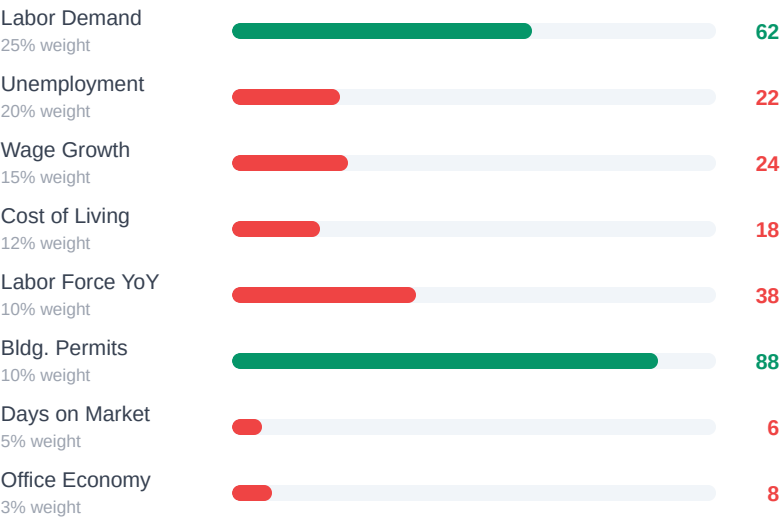
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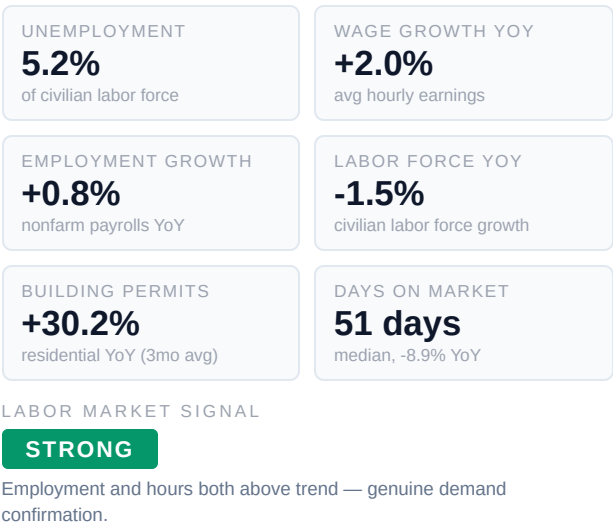
38.8th percentile

Rank 37 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.8th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its labor demand and cost of living metrics. The city's labor demand composite score of 5.87, which combines a 0.76% employment growth rate and a 0.508% weekly hours deviation above its own trend, suggests genuine demand expansion. Additionally, the cost of living, with a PSF of \$340/sqft and an hourly wage of \$38.44, resulting in a ratio of 8.84, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of 0.76% and weekly hours deviation of 0.508% above trend signal genuine demand expansion in the Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.87, ranking in the 62nd percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 5.20%, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market with some slack. This means that while it may be slightly challenging for businesses to hire, the market is not extremely competitive, and wage pressure is moderate. Businesses may need to offer competitive wages to attract top talent in this market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 2.02%, ranking in the 24th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but not extremely rapidly, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not dramatically. As a result, businesses may need to balance wage increases with other benefits to attract and retain talent.

Cost of Living

The cost of living in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom, with a PSF of \$340/sqft and an hourly wage of \$38.44, resulting in a ratio of 8.84, ranks in the 18th percentile, indicating a relatively expensive market. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may offset the moderate wage growth. Businesses may need to consider this when determining compensation packages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is contracting at a rate of -1.54% year-over-year, ranking in the 38th percentile, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This contraction may pose a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is

decreasing. Businesses may need to be more aggressive in their recruitment efforts to attract talent in this market.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom has increased by 30.25% year-over-year, ranking in the 88th percentile, indicating a significant expansion of housing supply. This increase suggests that developer confidence is high, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which may lead to increased affordability and a more attractive environment for relocating workers.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 51 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 8.9%, ranking in the 6th percentile, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This means that homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find available housing. Businesses may need to consider this when relocating employees to the area.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom is 0.78, ranking in the 8th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom metro area offers a mix of genuine labor demand expansion and a relatively tight labor market, but its high cost of living and shrinking labor force pose significant challenges for businesses. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's expensive market, which may require wage premiums to attract talent, potentially offsetting the benefits of moderate wage growth and a strong labor market.

San Diego

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad

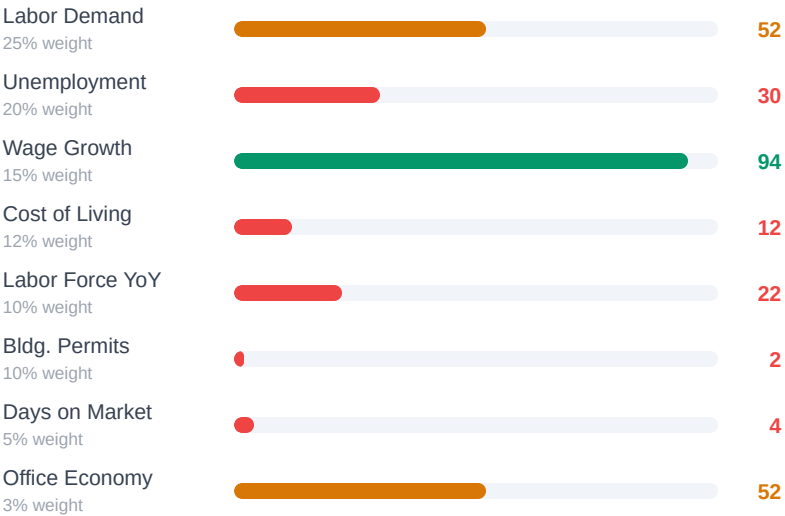
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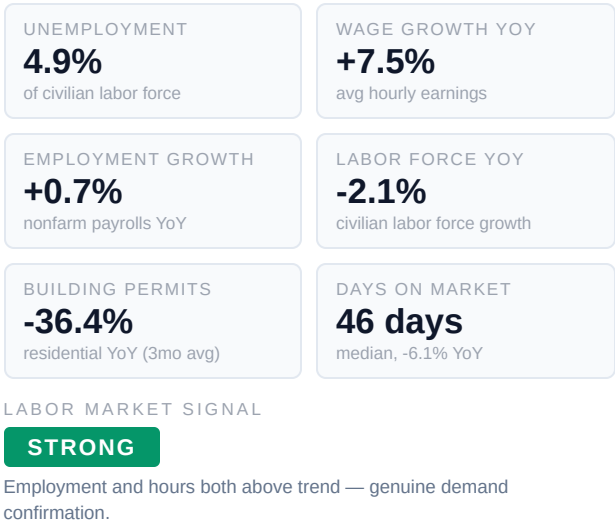
38.7th percentile

Rank 38 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a composite score driven largely by its high wage growth and low unemployment rate, which are 7.50% and 4.90%, respectively. The city's economic character is defined by these two metrics, indicating a tight labor market with rising labor costs. Specifically, the wage growth rate of 7.50% and unemployment rate of 4.90% suggest a competitive job market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 0.70% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +0.152% from its own trend, signaling a genuine demand expansion. This combination indicates that the city is experiencing modest job growth, with hours worked above the trend, suggesting that employers are increasing their workforce and workload. The labor demand composite score of 5.43 corresponds to a near-median percentile rank of 52nd.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 4.90%, which corresponds to a below-average percentile rank of 30th, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as the pool of available workers is smaller, and may need to offer competitive wages to attract talent. The tight labor market implies upward pressure on wages.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 7.50%, which is a top-tier growth rate, ranking in the 94th percentile. This rapid wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising quickly, while workers are experiencing increased purchasing power. The high wage growth rate may be a challenge for businesses looking to control labor costs.

Cost of Living

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a cost of living score that corresponds to a bottom-tier percentile rank of 12th, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$587/sqft to \$44.28/hr, or 13.26. Although the PSF is falling by 3.5% year-over-year, the city remains relatively expensive compared to its peers. This means that businesses may need to offer wage premiums to attract and retain talent, as the high cost of living may offset the city's other advantages.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is shrinking at a rate of -2.06% year-over-year, indicating a contracting labor pool. This decline in labor force growth suggests that the city may face structural headwinds in hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing. Businesses may need to adapt their hiring strategies to this shrinking labor pool.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has decreased by 36.38% year-over-year, indicating a tightening housing supply. This sharp decline in building permits signals that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of new housing is not keeping pace with demand. This may exacerbate the city's existing affordability challenges.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad is 46 days, with a year-over-year decrease of 6.1%. This relatively fast pace of home sales suggests that the city's housing market is competitive, and relocating workers may face challenges in finding available housing. The low days on market percentile rank of 4th indicates a hot market.

Office Economy

San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad has a professional and office worker share that corresponds to a near-median percentile rank of 52nd, with a composite score of 2.58. This suggests that the city has a moderately deep talent pool in professional and office sectors, making it suitable for businesses in tech, finance, and consulting. However, it may be less suited for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented workforces.

The San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad metro area offers businesses a highly competitive labor market with rising wages, but also presents significant challenges in terms of affordability and labor supply. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's extremely low ranking in building permits, which threatens to exacerbate the existing affordability crisis and limit the city's ability to accommodate a growing workforce.

Milwaukee

Milwaukee-Waukesha

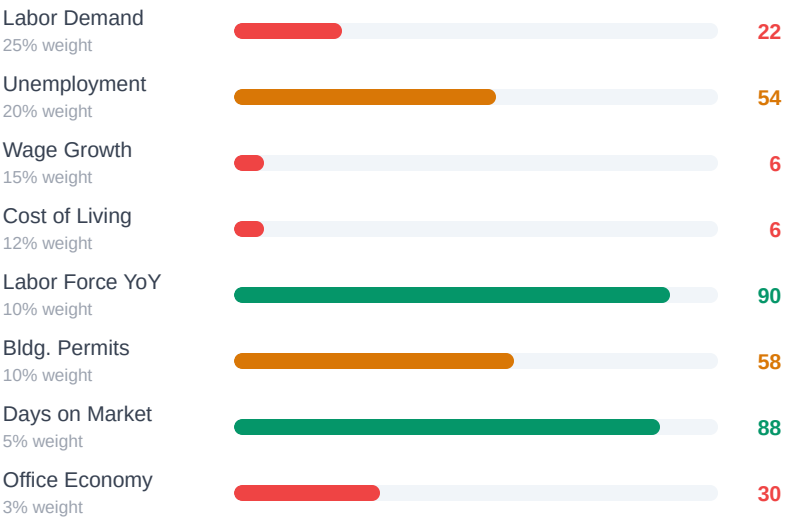
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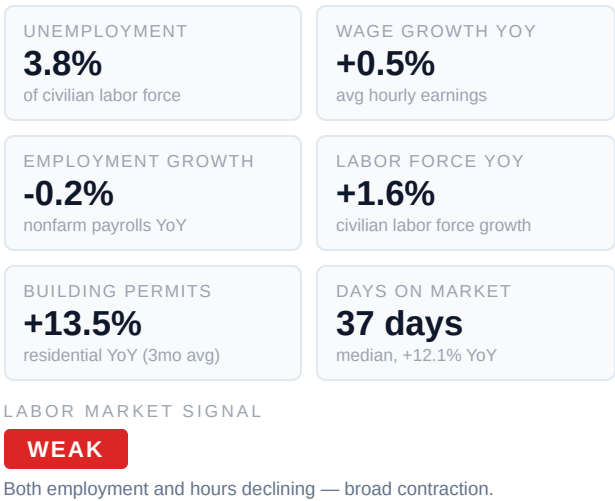
38.0th percentile

Rank 39 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area has an overall grade of C, ranking 38th out of 50 US metros, with a composite score defined largely by its low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, scoring 22nd and 6th percentile, respectively. The labor demand composite score of 3.95 and wage growth of +0.52% year-over-year are key metrics that characterize this city's current economic landscape. With an employment growth rate of -0.25% and weekly hours deviation of -1.588%, the city's labor market is experiencing contraction.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.25% and weekly hours deviation of -1.588% indicate a contraction in labor demand, signaling that the city is experiencing a decline in job creation and a decrease in working hours. This combination suggests that the labor market is not expanding, and businesses may face challenges in finding skilled workers. The labor demand composite score of 3.95, ranking 22nd percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 3.80% places the city near the median, ranking 54th percentile, indicating a relatively balanced labor market with neither significant tightness nor slack. For businesses trying to hire, this means that while it may not be extremely difficult to find workers, there is also not an oversupply of labor, which could lead to moderate wage pressure. The unemployment rate suggests that the labor market is relatively stable.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +0.52% is stagnant, ranking 6th percentile, indicating that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. This slow wage growth suggests that businesses may not face immediate pressure to increase salaries, but it also implies that workers may not have strong bargaining power. The stagnant wage growth has implications for both employers and workers.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$228/sqft and an earnings ratio of \$35.76/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.38, ranks 6th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The 2.2% year-over-year increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums, as the high cost of living may deter potential employees.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is growing at a rate of +1.57% year-over-year, ranking 90th percentile, indicating that the workforce supply is expanding. This growth in labor force supply suggests that businesses may have an easier time finding skilled workers, as the pool of

potential employees is increasing. The implication is that hiring capacity is improving.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is +13.52%, ranking 58th percentile, indicating that housing supply is expanding. This increase in building permits suggests that developer confidence is rising, and future housing supply is likely to improve, which could lead to better affordability and workforce accommodation. The expanding housing supply is a positive sign for the city's future.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 37 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.1%, ranking 88th percentile, indicating a slower market. This means that homes are sitting on the market for longer, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city. The slower market could be beneficial for individuals looking to buy or rent homes.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 2.06, ranking 30th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies. However, it may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as logistics or manufacturing.

The Milwaukee-Waukesha metro area offers businesses a relatively stable labor market and expanding workforce supply, but it is constrained by low labor demand and stagnant wage growth. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's relatively high cost of living, which may require businesses to offer wage premiums to attract talent. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its challenges in labor demand and affordability.

Denver

Denver-Aurora-Centennial

C-

CRITICAL

36.6th percentile

Rank 40 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0-100)

Labor Demand		68
25% weight		
Unemployment		12
20% weight		
Wage Growth		28
15% weight		
Cost of Living		61
12% weight		
Labor Force YoY		6
10% weight		
Bldg. Permits		16
10% weight		
Days on Market		30
5% weight		
Office Economy		64
3% weight		

KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT 4.6% of civilian labor force	WAGE GROWTH YOY +2.1% avg hourly earnings
EMPLOYMENT GROWTH +0.1% nonfarm payrolls YoY	LABOR FORCE YOY -3.0% civilian labor force growth
BUILDING PERMITS -19.6% residential YoY (3mo avg)	DAYS ON MARKET 58 days median, -3.3% YoY
LABOR MARKET SIGNAL STRONG Employment and hours both above trend — genuine demand confirmation.	

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 36.6th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its labor demand, with a composite score in the 68th percentile, and its high unemployment rate, which stands at 4.60%, ranking it in the 12th percentile. These two metrics signal a complex labor market with both positive and negative trends.

Labor Demand

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area has an employment growth rate of +0.10% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.564% from its own trend, indicating genuine demand expansion. This combination signals that the city is experiencing an increase in jobs and hours worked, suggesting a strong labor market. The labor demand composite score of 5.94 further supports this, ranking in the 68th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 4.60%, which is relatively high, ranking in the 12th percentile. This indicates that the labor market has some slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, this also suggests weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses that rely on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is +2.15%, which is below average, ranking in the 28th percentile. This moderate wage growth rate suggests that labor costs for employers are increasing, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is not growing rapidly. This could impact businesses that are sensitive to labor costs.

Cost of Living

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a cost of living score that ranks in the 61st percentile, with a PSF of \$279/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$43.51/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.41. This indicates that the city is relatively affordable compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is falling by -3.1% YoY further supports this, making it an attractive location for talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is shrinking at a rate of -2.99% year-over-year, ranking in the 6th percentile. This contraction in labor force supply poses a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Denver-Aurora-Centennial has decreased by -19.62% year-over-year, ranking in the 16th percentile. This sharp decline in permits suggests that housing supply is tightening, which could lead to future affordability issues and

challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Denver-Aurora-Centennial is 58 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -3.3%. This relatively fast pace of home sales, ranking in the 30th percentile, indicates a competitive market that may be challenging for relocating workers to find housing.

Office Economy

Denver-Aurora-Centennial has a professional and office worker share that ranks in the 64th percentile, with a composite score of 2.92. This suggests a deep talent pool suited for businesses in the tech, finance, consulting, and HQ sectors. However, it may be less suitable for industries with more industrial or logistics-oriented economies.

The Denver-Aurora-Centennial metro area offers businesses a complex labor market with both opportunities and challenges. While it has a strong labor demand and relatively affordable cost of living, its high unemployment rate, shrinking labor force, and tightening housing supply pose significant risks and constraints that decision-makers should carefully consider when evaluating this location for their business.

Riverside

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario

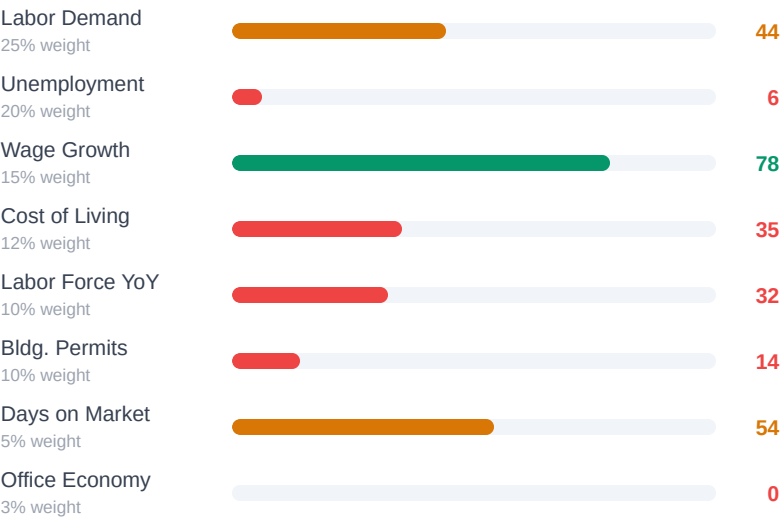
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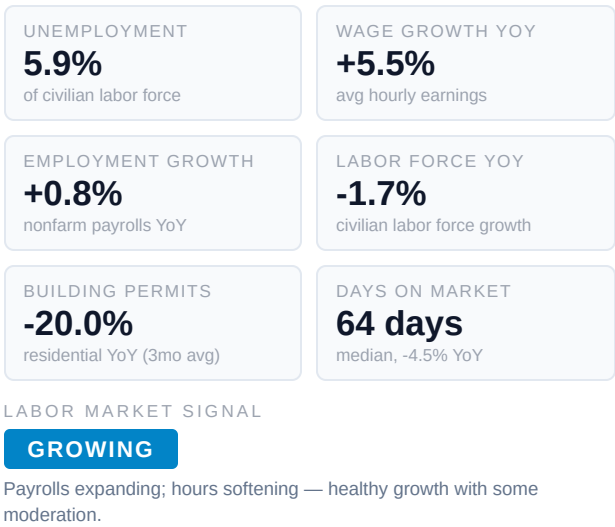
35.4th percentile

Rank 41 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.4th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its high wage growth rate of 5.51% year-over-year and its low unemployment rate of 5.90%, which signals a tight labor market. The combination of these metrics suggests that the city is experiencing a period of strong labor demand, but with significant constraints on hiring and talent attraction.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 0.75% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.149% from the city's own 12-month baseline. This combination signals a moderate expansion of labor demand, with some genuine demand for new jobs, but not at a rate that is significantly above trend. The labor demand composite score of 5.20 ranks near the median at 44th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.90%, ranking in the bottom tier at 6th percentile. This indicates a very tight labor market with little slack, making it challenging for businesses to hire new workers. As a result, businesses may face upward pressure on wages to attract and retain talent.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 5.51%, ranking above average at 78th percentile. This rapid wage growth signals rising labor costs for employers, but also increasing purchasing power for workers. Businesses should factor in the potential for higher labor costs when considering locating in this city.

Cost of Living

Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario has a cost of living score ranking below average at 35th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$330/sqft to \$35.45/hr, or 9.31. Although the city's PSF is falling -1.5% year-over-year, the overall affordability is still relatively low. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to offset the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is contracting at a rate of -1.74% year-over-year, ranking below average at 32nd percentile. This decline in labor force supply signals a structural headwind for hiring, making it even more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is falling sharply at -19.99% year-over-year, ranking in the bottom tier at 14th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a tightening of housing supply, which may lead to decreased affordability and increased competition for housing in the future.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is 64 days, with a year-over-year decline of -4.5%, ranking near the median at 54th percentile. This relatively fast pace of home sales may make it challenging for relocating workers to find housing, potentially affecting a business's ability to attract talent.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario is relatively low, ranking in the bottom tier at 0th percentile. This suggests that the city's talent pool is not particularly deep in specialized office roles, making it less suited for businesses in the tech, finance, or consulting sectors.

The Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario metro area offers businesses a unique combination of high wage growth and low unemployment, but also presents significant challenges in terms of hiring and talent attraction due to its tight labor market and high cost of living. The single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's declining labor force supply and tightening housing market, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and drive up labor costs.

Richmond

Richmond

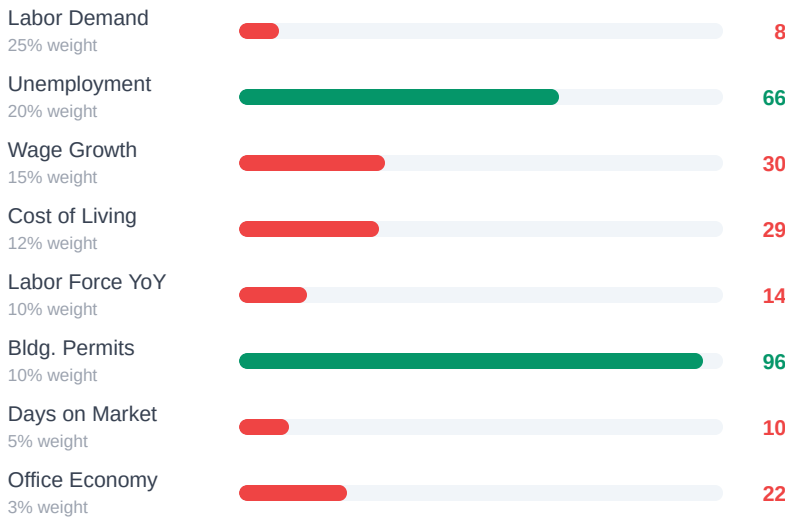
C-

CRITICAL

35.3th percentile

Rank 42 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.6%
of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+2.4%
avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.8%
nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-2.6%
civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

+83.8%
residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

44 days
median, -4.3% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Richmond metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.3th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a labor demand composite score of 2.93, and its high building permits growth, with a year-over-year change of +83.77%. These metrics signal a city with a struggling job market but a rapidly expanding housing supply.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Richmond is -0.82% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.219%. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are slightly above trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding talent to fill new positions.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Richmond is 3.60%, which ranks in the 66th percentile, indicating a relatively tight labor market. This means that businesses may face challenges in hiring, as there are fewer unemployed workers available to fill positions, and may need to offer higher wages to attract talent. However, this also suggests that the local consumer demand is relatively strong.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Richmond is +2.40%, which is below average, ranking in the 30th percentile. This moderate wage growth suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a slower pace, and worker purchasing power is increasing, but not rapidly. This may be a concern for businesses looking to keep labor costs under control.

Cost of Living

Richmond has a cost of living score that ranks in the 29th percentile, with a PSF of \$226/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$35.92/hr, resulting in a ratio of 6.29. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive compared to its peers. The fact that PSF is rising by +0.9% year-over-year further exacerbates the affordability issue, making it challenging for businesses to attract talent without offering wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Richmond is contracting at a rate of -2.57% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This signals a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of available workers is decreasing, making it more challenging for businesses to find the talent they need.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits in Richmond is +83.77%, which is in the top tier, ranking in the 96th percentile. This rapid expansion of housing supply signals that future affordability and workforce accommodation may improve, as more housing options become available, potentially attracting more workers to the area.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Richmond is 44 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -4.3%. This indicates a relatively fast-paced market, where homes are selling quickly, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. This may be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Richmond is 1.74, ranking in the 22nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This suggests that the city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics companies, and less suited for tech, finance, or consulting firms that rely on specialized office workers.

The Richmond metro area offers a unique combination of a struggling job market and a rapidly expanding housing supply, which may present both opportunities and challenges for businesses. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor pool, which may make it challenging to find and attract the talent needed to drive business growth.

Memphis

Memphis

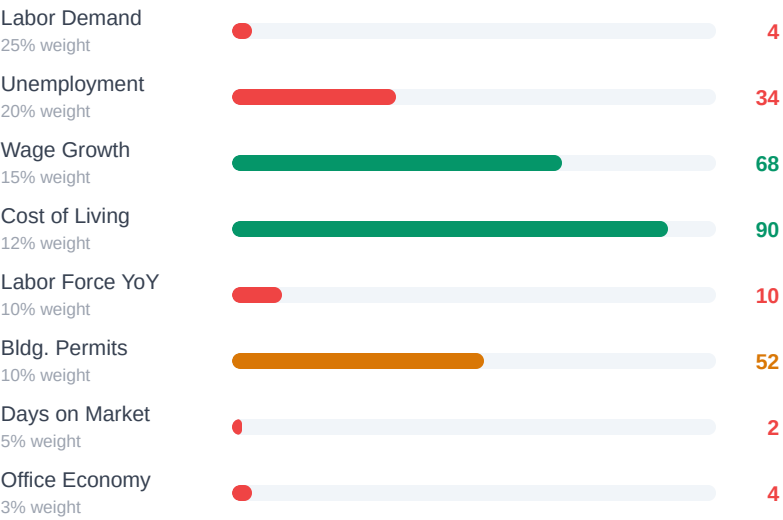
C-

CRITICAL

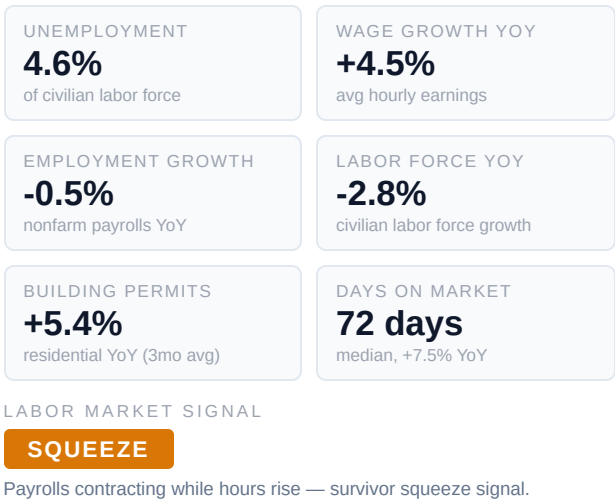
35.2th percentile

Rank 43 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Memphis has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 35.2th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score of 2.11, and its high cost of living affordability, with a ratio of \$153/sqft to \$33.22/hr, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. The labor demand and cost of living metrics are crucial in understanding the city's current economic state, with the labor demand being in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile.

Labor Demand

Memphis has an employment growth rate of -0.49% and a weekly hours deviation of +1.586% from its own trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, as the city is experiencing job losses while hours are above trend, indicating a survivor squeeze where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This suggests that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Memphis is 4.60%, which is below average, ranking at the 34th percentile. This indicates that the market has some slack, but it is not extremely loose, making it moderately challenging for businesses to hire. The practical implication for a business trying to hire in Memphis is that it may face some competition for talent, but it is not an extremely tight market.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Memphis is +4.52%, which is above average, ranking at the 68th percentile. This indicates that wages are rising faster than in most cities, which means that employer labor costs are increasing, but worker purchasing power is also improving. This could be beneficial for businesses that want to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

Memphis has a cost of living ratio of \$153/sqft to \$33.22/hr, with the PSF falling by -2.5% YoY, making it a very affordable city, ranking in the top tier at the 90th percentile. This means that the city has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live comfortably without requiring wage premiums. This could be a significant draw for businesses looking to relocate or expand.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Memphis is shrinking, with a year-over-year growth rate of -2.77%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile. This indicates that the labor pool is contracting, which could create a structural headwind for hiring and business expansion. Businesses may need to consider this when planning their workforce needs.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Memphis is increasing, with a year-over-year change of +5.41%, ranking near the median at the 52nd percentile. This suggests that housing supply is expanding, which could improve affordability and accommodation for the workforce. However, the growth rate is not extremely high, so it may not be enough to keep up with demand.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Memphis is 72 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 2nd percentile. This indicates that homes are sitting on the market for a relatively long time, making it a slower and more accessible market for workers relocating to the city. However, this could also signal a weakening demand for housing.

Office Economy

Memphis has a relatively shallow professional talent pool, with an office economy percentile rank of 4th percentile. This means that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, it may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The city of Memphis offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a relatively low unemployment rate, making it an attractive location for companies looking to reduce costs. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's low labor demand and shrinking labor force, which could create challenges for hiring and expansion. Decision-makers should carefully consider these factors when evaluating Memphis as a potential location for their business.

Fresno

Fresno

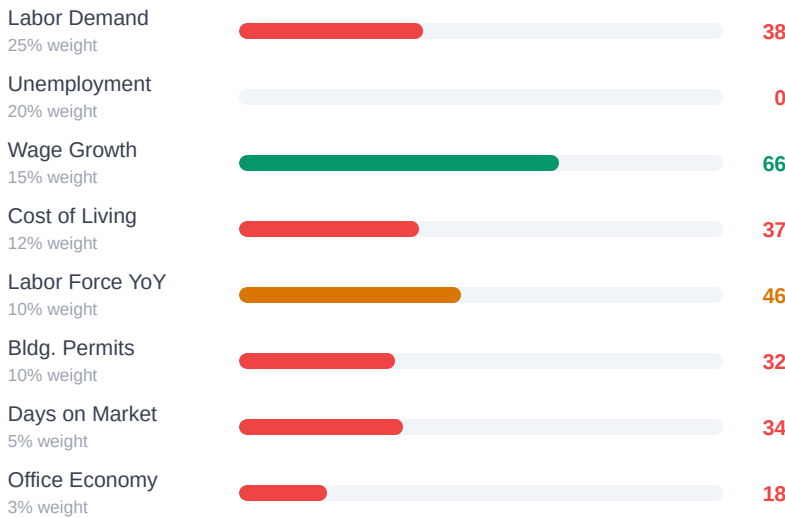
C-

CRITICAL

33.8th percentile

Rank 44 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

7.8%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+4.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.8%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.3%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-6.9%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

58 days

median, -1.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

Fresno, with an overall grade of C- and a composite score ranking it 33.8th out of 50 US metros, is characterized by its below-average labor demand and high unemployment rate, with 7.80% of the labor force unemployed. The labor demand composite score of 4.90 and unemployment rate are the two metrics that most define this city's current economic character, with the latter being a significant concern for businesses looking to hire. Specifically, the combination of a low labor demand score and high unemployment rate signals a challenging environment for businesses.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Fresno is +0.79% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.503% from the city's own 12-month baseline, indicating a labor market that is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, rather than a survivor squeeze, as hours are not above trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.90 is below average, ranking 38th percentile.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Fresno is 7.80%, which is the bottom tier, ranking 0th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire in this market, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The high unemployment rate has a practical implication for businesses, as it may lead to a larger pool of potential candidates, but also potentially weaker consumer spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Fresno is +4.51%, which is above average, ranking 66th percentile, indicating moderate to fast wage growth. This implies that employer labor costs are rising, while worker purchasing power is increasing. As a result, businesses may need to factor in higher labor costs, while also considering the potential benefits of a workforce with increasing purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Fresno has a cost of living score that ranks 37th percentile, with a PSF of \$263/sqft and an average hourly earnings of \$34.06/hr, resulting in a ratio of 7.72. This indicates that the city is below average in terms of affordability, making it less attractive for talent without wage premiums. The fact that PSF is rising +1.1% year-over-year relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability concern.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Fresno is contracting at a rate of -1.30% year-over-year, which is near the median, ranking 46th percentile. This means that the workforce supply is shrinking, presenting a structural headwind for hiring. As a result, businesses may face challenges in

finding and retaining talent in this market.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in residential building permits in Fresno is -6.89%, which is below average, ranking 32nd percentile. This indicates that housing supply is tightening, which may lead to future affordability concerns and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce. The decline in building permits signals a potential supply squeeze, making it essential for businesses to consider the long-term implications of this trend.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Fresno is 58 days, with a year-over-year direction of -1.7%. This indicates a relatively fast market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find housing. The low days on market suggests a competitive housing market, which may be a concern for businesses looking to attract talent from other areas.

Office Economy

Fresno has a professional and office worker share that ranks 18th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool in these sectors. This makes the city less suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. However, the city may be more suitable for businesses with industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

In conclusion, Fresno offers a labor market with significant slack, which may make it easier for businesses to hire, but also presents challenges in terms of labor demand and affordability. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker to factor in is the high unemployment rate and its potential impact on local consumer demand, making it essential to carefully consider the city's economic character before making a location decision.

Indianapolis

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood

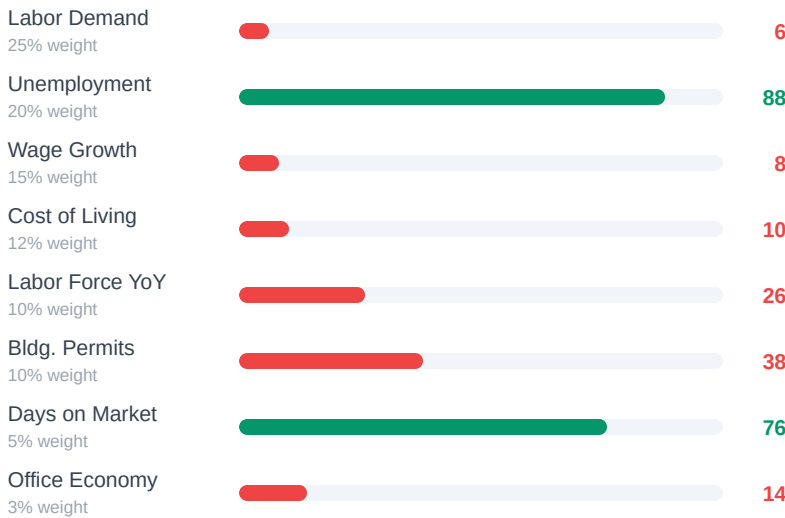
C-

CRITICAL

32.1th percentile

Rank 45 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

3.3%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+0.6%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-1.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.9%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-3.4%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

53 days

median, +12.8% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it at the 32.1th percentile out of 50 US metros. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with a composite score in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, and its tight unemployment market, with a rate of 3.30% ranking it in the top tier at the 88th percentile. Specifically, the employment growth rate of -1.05% and weekly hours deviation of +0.471% signal a contraction in labor demand.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is -1.05%, indicating a decline in job additions, while the weekly hours deviation is +0.471%, suggesting that remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, characteristic of a survivor squeeze. This combination signals a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market. The labor demand composite score of 2.36 ranks in the bottom tier at the 6th percentile, further emphasizing the weakness in labor demand.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 3.30%, ranking it in the top tier at the 88th percentile, indicating a tight labor market with low unemployment. This tight market implies that businesses may face challenges in hiring, with more wage pressure due to the limited availability of workers. The low unemployment rate suggests that the local labor market has slack, but it is relatively minimal.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is +0.58%, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 8th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a flat cost environment for employers but weak bargaining power for workers. The moderate wage growth rate suggests that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly.

Cost of Living

Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood has a cost of living ratio of \$165/sqft to \$33.86/hr, with a ratio of 4.87, ranking it in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, indicating that the city is relatively expensive. The PSF is increasing by 4.4% year-over-year, further contributing to the high cost of living. This expense means that the city may require wage premiums to attract talent, as its affordability is lower than many of its peers.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is contracting at a rate of -1.87% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 26th percentile. This decline in the labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, as the pool of available workers is shrinking. The negative growth rate suggests that businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is decreasing by 3.35% year-over-year, ranking it below average at the 38th percentile. This decline in building permits signals a potential tightening of the housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. The decrease in permits suggests that developer confidence may be waning.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is 53 days, with a year-over-year increase of 12.8%, ranking it above average at the 76th percentile. This increase in days on market suggests a slower, more buyer-friendly market, which could make it easier for relocating workers to find housing. However, the relatively high days on market may also indicate a decrease in demand.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers in Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood is relatively low, with a composite score ranking it in the bottom tier at the 14th percentile. This suggests that the city may not have a deep talent pool for tech, finance, or consulting businesses, but could be more suited for industrial or logistics-dominant economies. The low ranking indicates that businesses requiring specialized office skills may need to look elsewhere.

The Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood metro area offers a business a tight labor market with low unemployment, but this also means that hiring may be challenging due to wage pressure. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the low labor demand and contracting labor force, which could limit the availability of qualified workers and hinder business growth. Overall, the city's economic character is defined by its low labor demand and tight labor market, making it essential for businesses to carefully consider these factors when making location decisions.

Jacksonville

Jacksonville

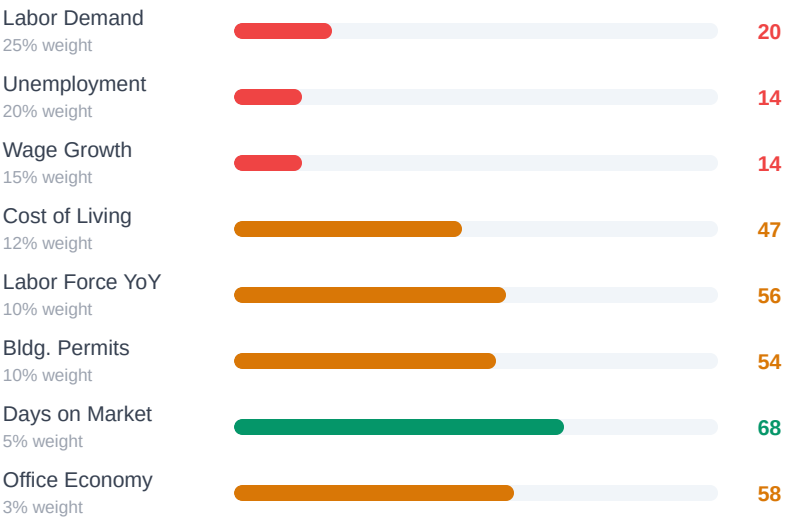
C-

CRITICAL

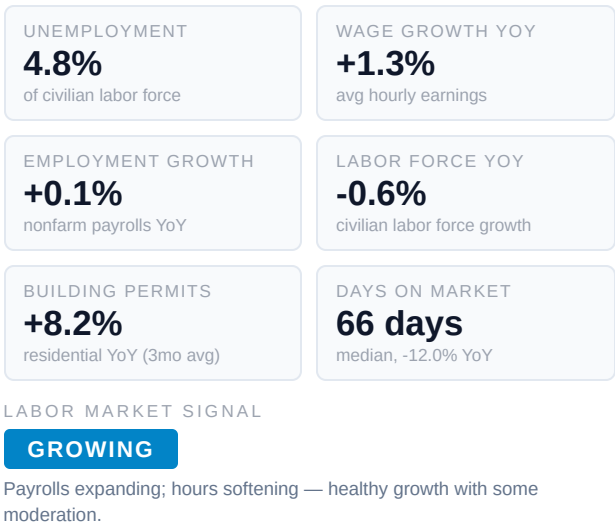
31.7th percentile

Rank 46 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The city of Jacksonville has an overall grade of C- with a composite score ranking it 31.7th percentile out of 50 US metros. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand composite score of 3.86, ranking it in the 20th percentile, and its high unemployment rate of 4.80%, ranking it in the 14th percentile. These metrics signal a challenging labor market with limited job growth and high unemployment.

Labor Demand

Jacksonville's employment growth rate is a modest +0.06% year-over-year, while weekly hours are deviating -0.520% from its own trend. This combination signals a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. The low labor demand composite score of 3.86 further reinforces this signal.

Unemployment

The city's unemployment rate stands at 4.80%, ranking it in the 14th percentile, indicating a labor market with significant slack. This means that businesses trying to hire in Jacksonville may find it easier to staff, but may also face weaker local consumer demand. The high unemployment rate suggests that the market is not tight, giving employers more flexibility in hiring.

Wage Growth

Jacksonville's year-over-year wage growth rate is +1.34%, ranking it in the 14th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth means that employer labor costs are not rising rapidly, but worker purchasing power is also not increasing significantly. The low wage growth rate may make it challenging for businesses to attract and retain top talent.

Cost of Living

With a cost of living ratio of \$213/sqft vs \$37.45/hr, Jacksonville ranks in the 47th percentile, indicating a near-median affordability score. The city's PSF is falling -1.4% year-over-year, making it more affordable relative to wages. This means that Jacksonville has a talent attraction advantage, as workers can afford to live in the city without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The city's civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.56% year-over-year, ranking it in the 56th percentile. This means that the labor force supply is shrinking, creating a structural headwind for hiring. Businesses may face challenges in finding qualified workers as the labor pool contracts.

Building Permits

Jacksonville's residential building permits are increasing at a rate of +8.24% year-over-year, ranking it in the 54th percentile. This signals that housing supply is expanding, which may improve affordability and workforce accommodation in the future. The increase in building permits suggests that developers are confident in the city's growth prospects.

Days on Market

The current median days on market in Jacksonville is 66 days, with a year-over-year decrease of -12.0%, ranking it in the 68th percentile. This indicates a relatively fast market, making it challenging for relocating workers to find homes. The low days on market suggests that the city's housing market is competitive.

Office Economy

Jacksonville's professional and office worker share ranks in the 58th percentile, indicating a near-median depth of talent pool. The city is suited for businesses that do not require a highly specialized knowledge-economy workforce, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be the best fit for tech, finance, or consulting firms that require a deep talent pool.

The city of Jacksonville offers businesses a relatively affordable cost of living and a large labor market with significant slack, making it easier to hire. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for businesses is the city's low labor demand and stagnant wage growth, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and create challenges for talent attraction and retention. Overall, Jacksonville's economic character presents both opportunities and challenges for businesses considering location decisions.

Grand Rapids

Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood

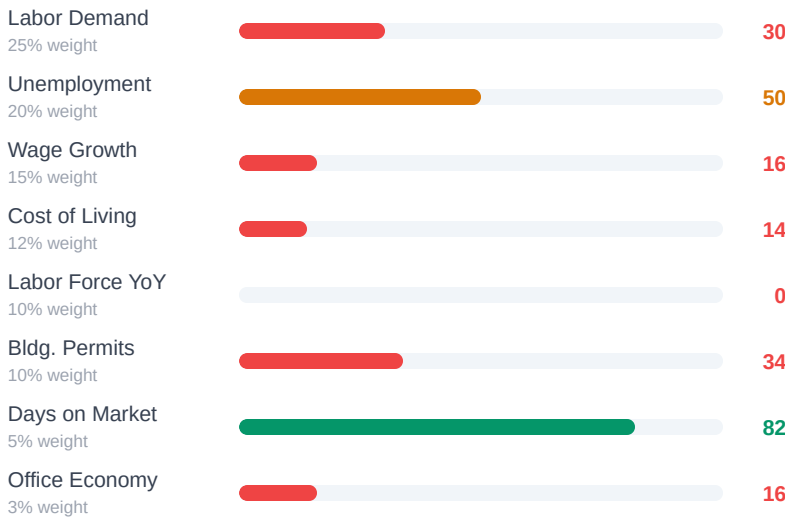
D

EMERGENCY

29.6th percentile

Rank 47 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.2%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.4%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

+0.7%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-7.2%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-5.7%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

42 days

median, +7.7% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

GROWING

Payrolls expanding; hours softening — healthy growth with some moderation.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 29.6th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 4.59. This city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand, with employment growth of +0.68% and weekly hours deviation of -0.658%, as well as its stagnant wage growth of +1.41%. The combination of these metrics suggests a lack of genuine demand expansion in the labor market.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of +0.68% and weekly hours deviation of -0.658% signal a contraction in labor demand, indicating that the city is not experiencing genuine demand expansion. This combination suggests that the labor market is not strong, with fewer jobs being added and hours worked below trend. The labor demand composite score of 4.59, ranking in the 30th percentile, further supports this assessment.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.20% indicates a near-median labor market, neither extremely tight nor extremely slack. This rate suggests that businesses may face some challenges in hiring, but it is not an insurmountable obstacle. However, the market is not loose enough to provide a significant advantage in terms of ease of hiring.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.41% is stagnant, ranking in the 16th percentile. This slow wage growth implies that labor costs for employers are not rising rapidly, but it also means that worker purchasing power is not increasing significantly. As a result, businesses may not face strong pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have the disposable income to drive local consumer demand.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$215/sqft and an earnings ratio of 6.60, ranks in the 14th percentile, indicating that it is relatively expensive. The fact that PSF is rising by 1.9% YoY relative to wages further exacerbates the affordability issue. This means that the city may struggle to attract talent without offering wage premiums to compensate for the high cost of living.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -7.20% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force growth poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and recruit talent.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -5.72%, indicating a tightening of housing supply. This decline in permits suggests that the city's future affordability and workforce accommodation may be at risk, as the supply of housing is not expanding to meet demand.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 42 days, with a year-over-year increase of 7.7%, ranking in the 82nd percentile. This slower market means that homes are sitting longer before being sold, making it more accessible for workers relocating to the city to find housing.

Office Economy

The city's professional talent pool is relatively shallow, ranking in the 16th percentile. This suggests that the city is not well-suited for businesses that require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech, finance, or consulting firms. Instead, the city may be more suitable for industries with fewer specialized roles, such as industrial or logistics-dominant economies.

The Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood metro area offers businesses a relatively slow-paced and affordable housing market, but it is constrained by a lack of labor demand, stagnant wage growth, and a shrinking labor force. The single biggest risk or constraint for a decision-maker is the city's limited labor pool and lack of specialized talent, which may hinder a business's ability to grow and expand in the area.

Louisville

Louisville-Jefferson County

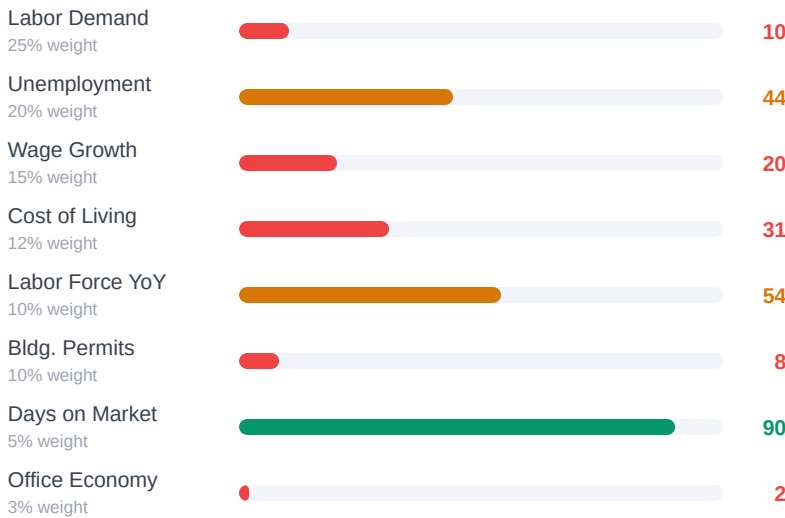
D

EMERGENCY

28.7th percentile

Rank 48 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

4.1%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.7%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.1%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-0.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-31.1%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

45 days

median, +12.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking 28.7th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 2.98. The city's economic character is most defined by its weak labor demand, with employment growth of -0.13% year-over-year, and its slow wage growth, at +1.74% year-over-year. These metrics signal a challenging environment for businesses looking to expand or relocate.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate of -0.13% year-over-year, combined with a weekly hours deviation of +1.140% from the city's own trend, suggests a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles. This indicates a lack of genuine demand expansion, as hours are above trend during a period of job losses. The labor demand composite score of 2.98, ranking in the bottom tier at the 10th percentile, further reinforces this notion.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate of 4.10% is near the median, ranking at the 44th percentile, indicating a moderate level of slack in the labor market. This means that businesses may not face extreme difficulty in hiring, but may still encounter some competition for talent. The relatively average unemployment rate suggests that wage pressure is not excessively high, but still present.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate of +1.74% is below average, ranking at the 20th percentile, indicating stagnant wage growth. This slow wage growth implies a relatively flat cost environment for employers, but also weak bargaining power for workers. As a result, businesses may not face significant labor cost increases, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

The city's cost of living, with a PSF of \$178/sqft and an earnings ratio of 5.67, ranks at the 31st percentile, indicating a below-average level of affordability. However, since the PSF is not falling year-over-year, the affordability score is not driven by declining housing costs. This means that the city may not offer a significant talent attraction advantage without wage premiums, as the cost of living is relatively high compared to peers.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force is contracting at a rate of -0.83% year-over-year, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This represents a structural headwind for hiring, as the supply of potential workers is decreasing. Businesses may face challenges in finding and recruiting talent in this environment.

Building Permits

The year-over-year change in building permits is -31.05%, indicating a sharp decline in housing supply expansion. This signals a potential supply squeeze building ahead, which could lead to decreased affordability and increased challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Days on Market

The current median days on market is 45 days, with a year-over-year increase of +12.5%, ranking at the 90th percentile. This indicates a slower market, where homes are sitting longer before being sold. For a worker relocating to this city, this means a more accessible and less competitive housing market.

Office Economy

The share of professional and office workers is 0.32, ranking at the 2nd percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is best suited for businesses that do not require a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as industrial or logistics-dominant companies. However, it may not be ideal for tech, finance, or consulting businesses that rely on specialized office roles.

The Louisville-Jefferson County metro area offers a relatively flat cost environment and a moderate labor market, but is constrained by weak labor demand, slow wage growth, and a shrinking labor pool. The single biggest risk or constraint for businesses considering this location is the potential supply squeeze in housing, which could lead to decreased affordability and challenges in accommodating a growing workforce.

Chicago

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin

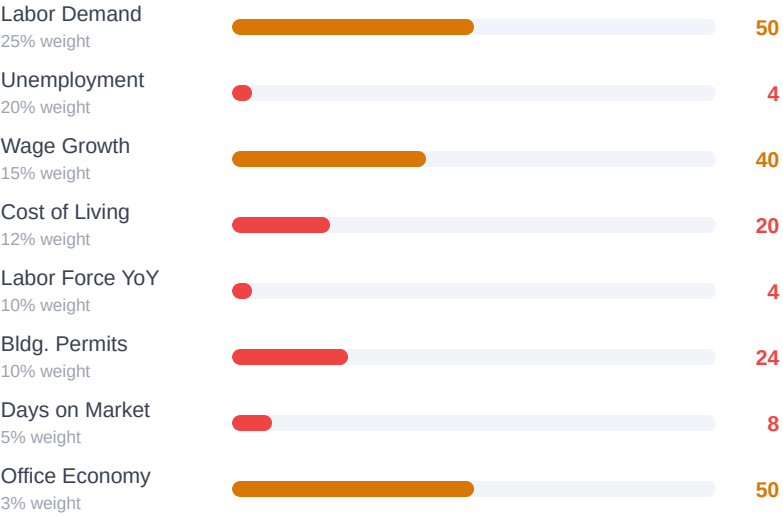
D

EMERGENCY

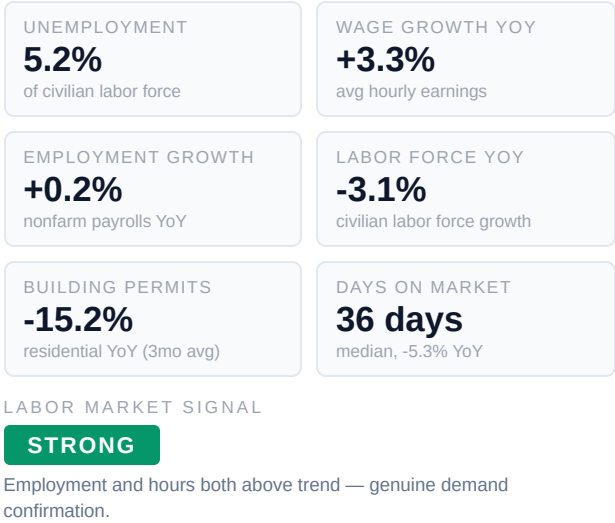
26.4th percentile

Rank 49 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS



ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 26.4th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 5.43. This city's economic character is most defined by its high unemployment rate of 5.20% and its negative labor force growth rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating significant challenges in the job market. The combination of these metrics suggests a struggling local economy.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +0.22% YoY, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.823%, indicating a near-median labor demand composite score. This combination signals a modest expansion in genuine demand, as hours are running above trend during a period of slow job growth. However, the overall labor demand remains lackluster.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 5.20%, ranking in the bottom tier at the 4th percentile, indicating a significant amount of slack in the job market. This means that businesses may find it easier to hire workers, but the local consumer demand may be weaker due to the high unemployment rate. As a result, companies may need to consider the potential impact on their customer base.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is +3.28%, ranking near the median at the 40th percentile, indicating moderate wage growth. This rate suggests that labor costs for employers are rising, but at a pace that is not excessively high, while worker purchasing power is increasing. However, the wage growth may not be sufficient to drive significant economic expansion.

Cost of Living

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has a cost of living score that ranks in the 20th percentile, with a PSF of \$220/sqft and average hourly earnings of \$37.65, resulting in a ratio of 5.84. This indicates that the city is relatively expensive, which may make it challenging to attract talent without offering wage premiums. The 3.3% YoY increase in PSF further exacerbates the affordability concerns.

Labor Force Growth

The labor force in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is contracting at a rate of -3.13% YoY, indicating a shrinking labor pool. This decline in labor force supply poses a significant structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find the talent they need. As a result, companies may need to consider alternative locations or strategies to attract workers.

Building Permits

The number of building permits in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has decreased by -15.18% YoY, indicating a tightening of the housing supply. This decline in residential construction signals a potential supply squeeze, which may lead to decreased affordability and make it more difficult for workers to relocate to the area. As a result, businesses may face challenges in attracting and retaining talent.

Days on Market

The median days on market in Chicago-Naperville-Elgin is 36 days, with a YoY decrease of -5.3%, indicating a relatively fast-paced market. This suggests that homes are selling quickly, which may make it challenging for relocating workers to find suitable housing. However, the decreasing trend in days on market may indicate a normalization of the housing market.

Office Economy

Chicago-Naperville-Elgin has an office economy score that ranks near the median at the 50th percentile, with a share of professional and office workers at 2.54. This indicates a moderate depth of professional talent pool, making the city suitable for businesses that require a mix of office and industrial skills. However, the city may not be the best fit for businesses that require a highly specialized or deep knowledge-economy talent pool.

The Chicago-Naperville-Elgin metro area offers businesses a large and diverse economy, but its high unemployment rate and declining labor force growth pose significant risks. The single biggest constraint for decision-makers is the challenge of attracting and retaining talent due to the city's relatively high cost of living and tightening housing supply, which may require companies to offer wage premiums or consider alternative locations.

Detroit

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn

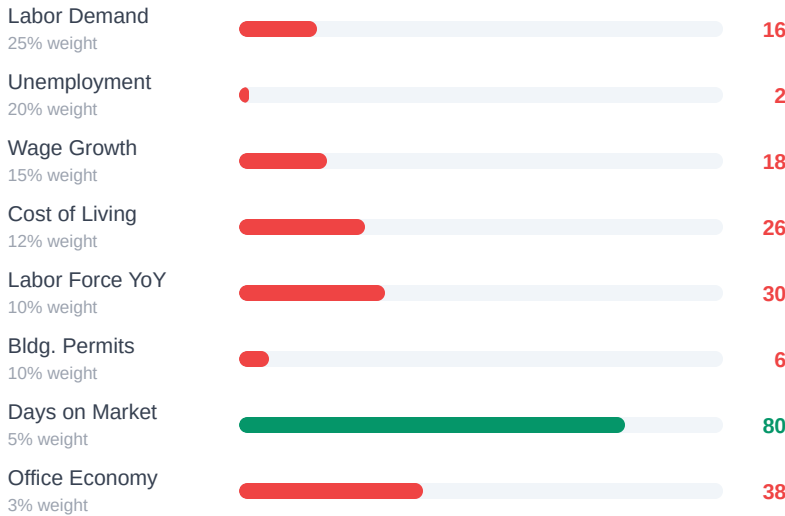
D

EMERGENCY

19.0th percentile

Rank 50 of 50 metros

METRIC SCORECARD — PERCENTILE SCORES (0–100)



KEY INDICATORS

UNEMPLOYMENT

5.7%

of civilian labor force

WAGE GROWTH YOY

+1.5%

avg hourly earnings

EMPLOYMENT GROWTH

-0.2%

nonfarm payrolls YoY

LABOR FORCE YOY

-1.8%

civilian labor force growth

BUILDING PERMITS

-33.0%

residential YoY (3mo avg)

DAYS ON MARKET

43 days

median, +7.5% YoY

LABOR MARKET SIGNAL

SQUEEZE

Payrolls contracting while hours rise — survivor squeeze signal.

ECONOMIC ANALYSIS

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area has an overall grade of D, ranking in the 19.0th percentile out of 50 US metros, with a labor demand composite score of 3.58, placing it in the bottom tier. The city's economic character is most defined by its low labor demand and high unemployment rate, with employment growth at -0.20% year-over-year and an unemployment rate of 5.70%. These metrics signal significant challenges for businesses looking to expand or relocate in the area.

Labor Demand

The employment growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is -0.20% year-over-year, and weekly hours are deviating from the trend by +0.439%. This combination signals a survivor squeeze, where remaining workers are absorbing the load of eliminated roles, rather than genuine demand expansion. The labor demand composite score of 3.58 is in the bottom tier, indicating a weak job market.

Unemployment

The unemployment rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 5.70%, placing it in the bottom tier. This signals a market with significant slack, making it easier for businesses to hire workers. However, the high unemployment rate also implies weaker local consumer demand, which could impact businesses reliant on local spending.

Wage Growth

The year-over-year wage growth rate in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is +1.48%, which is relatively slow. This moderate wage growth implies a relatively flat labor cost environment for employers, but also means workers have limited bargaining power. As a result, businesses may not face significant pressure to increase wages, but workers may not have strong purchasing power.

Cost of Living

Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has a cost of living score in the 26th percentile, with a price-to-salary ratio of \$186/sqft to \$37.53/hr, indicating a relatively affordable city. The fact that the PSF is rising 3.3% year-over-year, however, may erode this affordability advantage over time. The current affordability advantage could attract talent without requiring significant wage premiums.

Labor Force Growth

The civilian labor force in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is contracting at a rate of -1.76% year-over-year. This decline in labor force supply implies a structural headwind for hiring, making it challenging for businesses to find and retain workers. As the labor force shrinks, businesses may need to offer more competitive wages or benefits to attract talent.

Building Permits

The number of residential building permits in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn has decreased by -32.95% year-over-year. This sharp decline signals a tightening housing supply, which could lead to decreased affordability and make it harder for workers to relocate to the area. The reduced housing supply may constrain workforce growth and limit the city's ability to attract new businesses.

Days on Market

The median days on market for homes in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is 43 days, with a year-over-year increase of +7.5%. This slower market, ranked in the 80th percentile, makes it more accessible for workers relocating to the city, as they have more time to find a home. The rising days on market may also indicate a normalization of the housing market, rather than a demand-driven slowdown.

Office Economy

The professional and office worker share in Detroit-Warren-Dearborn is ranked in the 38th percentile, indicating a relatively shallow talent pool. This city is less suited for businesses requiring a deep knowledge-economy talent pool, such as tech or finance companies, but may be more suitable for industrial or logistics-dominant businesses.

The Detroit-Warren-Dearborn metro area offers businesses an affordable cost of living and a slower housing market, making it more accessible for relocating workers. However, the single biggest risk or constraint for decision-makers is the city's weak labor demand and high unemployment rate, which may limit the availability of skilled workers and constrain business growth.